

Education: **The State of the Discipline**

An exploration of existing statistical
data relating to staff equality in
UK higher education

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ABOUT BERA

The British Educational Research Association (BERA) is the leading authority on educational research in the UK, supporting and representing the community of scholars, practitioners and everyone engaged in and with educational research both nationally and internationally. BERA is a membership association and learned society committed to advancing research quality, building research capacity and fostering research engagement. We aim to inform the development of policy and practice by promoting the best quality evidence produced by educational research.

Our vision is for educational research to have a profound and positive influence on society. We support this by promoting and sustaining the work of educational researchers. Our membership, which is more than 2,500 strong, includes educational researchers, practitioners and doctoral students from the UK and around the globe.

Founded in 1974, BERA has since expanded into an internationally renowned association. We strive to be inclusive of the diversity of education research and scholarship, and welcome members from a wide range of disciplinary backgrounds, theoretical orientations, methodological approaches, sectoral interests and institutional affiliations. We encourage the development of productive relationships with other associations within and beyond the UK.

We run a major international conference each year alongside a diverse and engaging series of events, and publish high quality research in our peer-reviewed journals, reports, book series and the groundbreaking BERA Blog. We recognise excellence through our awards and fellowships, provide grants for research, support the career development of our members, and nurture an active peer community organised around networks, forums and special interest groups.

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EDUCATION: THE STATE OF THE DISCIPLINE

The State of the Discipline initiative aims to provide a clear, comprehensive account of the state of education as an academic discipline in universities; as a field of practice; and as a significant and central element of social and political policy in the four nations of the UK.

Reports from each stage of the initiative will equip stakeholders in every part of the sector with the most objective and powerful information on which to base their advocacy for the importance of education and education research. It will also be key to informing decision-making processes within BERA.

Two elements are central to the initiative:

- the definition of education as an academic discipline that shares characteristics with many other disciplines, including those that have been established for much longer in universities worldwide;
- the intersections between education research and practice including in teacher education and training, which in recent work has been articulated as ‘close-to-practice-research’.

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report was subject to peer-review from the steering group appointed by BERA to oversee the Education: The State of the Discipline initiative.

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Introduction from BERA: About this report

BERA has had a longstanding interest in the state of education: as an academic discipline in universities, as a field of practice, and as a significant and central element of social and political policy. In the last decade, the nature of work in universities has been subject to a range of significant changes. Some of these changes have been recognised by trade unions, for example, increased casualisation of the workforce and changes towards more teaching-only contracts. The Research Excellence Framework (REF) also continues to be an influence on the ways in which universities work. In 2019, mindful of the ongoing changes within many UK universities, with resultant impacts on BERA members, BERA Council approved the development of an initiative to examine the state of education as a discipline taking account of the four nations of the UK. The ultimate purpose of this initiative was to equip those interested in the development of education with the most objective and powerful information on which to base their advocacy for education.

In January 2020 BERA commissioned a systematic review (SR) which was designed to inform the state of the discipline initiative. The SR reviewed the research on the structures and processes – both formal and informal – that influence research activities in the UK. Following an open tender, the review was awarded to a team from the Universities of Dundee and Exeter, and their final report was published in September 2021 (Boyle et al., 2021).

Once the report and its recommendations had been considered by BERA's leadership committee, the association commissioned additional projects to explore the state of education further. One of those projects was a commission to analyse existing data in order to gain a more detailed understanding of the profile of academic staff working in education departments in universities in the UK, with particular regard to equality and diversity and protected characteristics under the Equality Act 2010. Various sources of data indicated that there were fewer women and ethnic minority colleagues in senior academic roles (professors, readers, senior lecturers, heads of school and department) in the discipline. However, there were no appropriate analyses of the data to look at career trajectories and seek to identify the points at which women and ethnic minority colleagues faced barriers to progression, or at which they exited the profession.

As well as being part of BERA's wider initiative concerning the state of education as an academic discipline, this work was driven by BERA's Race Equality Policy and commitment to address racial inequities within the research community.

It also affirmed BERA's commitment to bringing its resources and expertise to bear on wider issues of inequality and discrimination in education and society. In developing this particular project on staff equality, BERA has taken inspiration from colleagues in other learned societies, notably the work commissioned by the British Sociological Association (BSA) (Joseph-Salisbury et al., 2020) and more recently the British International Studies Association (BISA) and Political Studies Association (PSA) (Hanretty, 2021). Their work strongly influenced the nature of the original tender for the project.

Through an open tender, the commission for this research was awarded to Dina Zoe Belluigi, Jason Arday and Joanne O'Keeffe at Queen's University Belfast and the University of Glasgow, and it is in this report that the research team set out their analysis and findings. BERA wishes to extend gratitude to the research team for the time, dedication and care they have put into this project. Their report contributes to a more detailed understanding of issues of equality, inequality, diversity and discrimination for academic staff working in the UK in the discipline of education.

January 2023

Summary

This report presents findings on specific aspects of the composition and employment of academic staff in the discipline of education in higher education (HE) across the UK and in each of the devolved nations: England, Northern Ireland, Scotland and Wales. The findings are informed by analysing statistical data collected by HE institutions during the academic years 2015-16 to 2019-20, as reported to the Higher Education Statistics Agency (HESA).

The study was conducted in order to gain an understanding of the state of the discipline of education in the interests of addressing inequalities. It explored where certain markers of sameness and difference – in terms of characteristics of sex, ethnicity, age, disability, religious belief and nationality – may have affected staff employment between 2015 and 2020. This included analysing the percentages of staff, the proportions of groupings, and the rate of change in employment conditions, as captured in HESA data during the period researched. This enabled the researchers to identify the differential and, where possible to ascertain, the intersectional impacts on the access, positioning, attainment, progression and attrition of education staff. Main findings are summarised below.

GENERAL EMPLOYMENT CONDITIONS WHICH MAY HAVE AN IMPACT ON EQUALITY

When education is compared with all other disciplines in the UK HE sector there are a series of concerning findings about general

employment conditions for academic staff within education. These are of concern for equality.

The smaller rate of growth in the number of staff employed in education, which was less than that of the UK HE sector generally, was of concern. Growth was primarily in ‘teaching only’ contracts in education, with the proportion of ‘teaching and research’ contracts shrinking in the period studied.

More staff in education were employed in senior grades than in junior grades, differing from the pattern in the UK HE sector generally. Despite this, lower proportions of staff in education progressed to professorial level than in the UK HE sector.

A positive condition for the discipline was that a higher proportion of staff in education were on permanent contracts than in the UK HE sector generally. The proportion of education staff on fixed-term contracts decreased over the period studied, particularly staff in junior grades.

There were concerns about structural conditions for research in education. The proportion of staff on ‘research only’ contracts was significantly lower than in the UK HE sector as a whole. In education, the combined contracts of ‘research only’ and ‘teaching and research’ made up two-thirds of the proportions of staff contracts, which too was lower than in the UK HE sector generally.

STAFF COMPOSITION AND EMPLOYMENT CONDITIONS

The study analysed staff composition for what it revealed about possible inequalities. Although there was some consistency across the UK HE sector, there were also notable differences between devolved nations. This finding suggests that care should be exercised by scholars of higher education to differentiate between the devolved nations. This has been done below, with comparisons drawn with the UK HE sector and, where relevant, with the local HE sector of the devolved nation.

Sex

Overall, there were more female than male staff in education. However, the opposite was observed for particular minority ethnic groups, and for those whose primary nationality was not held in high-income countries.

Despite the smaller number of male staff in education overall, indications were that they were advantaged. Of the male staff, higher proportions were employed in ‘teaching and research’; in senior academic positions; at professorial level; and in senior management, than the proportions observed in female staff. It was found that the percentage of female staff working in education decreased consistently with age, while the percentage of male staff increased. On average, there was a shorter career duration for female staff in education at senior levels. The percentage of female staff progressing to professorships increased after age 41; for male staff the increase was sooner at age 31. By age 66, there were twice as many male professors in education as female professors.

In the devolved nations, Wales had the highest proportion of female staff in education. This was consistent with its local HE sector, which had the highest proportion of female staff compared to the UK HE sector. Northern Ireland had the lowest proportion of female staff in education, consistent with its local HE sector, which employed the lowest proportion of females in the UK. England was the only devolved nation to return values for ‘other’, in terms of sex, in education. However, the amounts returned were too small for statistical analysis.

Ethnicity

The proportion of staff recorded as ‘white’ was higher in education than that of the UK HE sector. While there were increases in access in staff recorded as black, Asian and minority ethnic (BAME) over the period studied, the rates of growth were insufficient to address the under-representation. Thus, in 2020, the proportion of those education staff recorded as BAME was less than half that of the UK HE sector.

Close analysis revealed that the increases in education staff recorded as BAME were primarily at junior level and through ‘teaching only’ contracts. Under-representation was most extreme for those categorised as black and Asian/Asian British Bangladeshi.

The devolved nation with the least ethnic diversity, and the highest proportion of staff recorded as white, was Northern Ireland. This was followed by Wales, Scotland and England.

Nationality

HESA datasets categorise the nationality of education staff by UK, EU, non-UK/EU, and individual countries, recording a ‘primary nationality’ only. It was found that

education was homogenous when it came to the nationalities of its staff. There were higher proportions of staff in education with UK primary nationality than the proportions observed in the whole UK HE sector. For staff with EU and non-EU/UK primary nationality, access to employment in education was thus proportionally far lower.

There was more diversity of nationalities held by education staff recorded as BAME. The proportion of those holding non-EU/UK and EU primary nationalities was higher than the proportion of those recorded as white. However, those holding UK primary nationality were the largest proportion of staff recorded as BAME in education, far higher than that observed in the UK HE sector.

A very small percentage of education staff had their recorded primary nationality from the Global South, at a lower percentage than that of the UK HE sector. Most of those education staff were positioned in junior positions. The percentage of staff employed from low-income countries in education was so small that it was rounded to zero.

While all the devolved nations employed higher proportions of staff in education with UK primary nationality than was evident in their respective local HE sectors, the largest proportion was in Wales, with considerable differences in proportions compared with those of England, Scotland and Northern Ireland. The largest proportion of staff recorded as EU primary nationality was in Northern Ireland (of which the majority held their primary nationality from the Republic of Ireland), followed by Scotland, England and Wales. Education in all the devolved nations employed considerably lower proportions of staff with EU

primary nationality than their respective local HE sectors. Of those employing staff with non-EU/UK primary nationality, Scotland employed the largest proportion, followed by England, Northern Ireland and Wales. These proportions were again significantly lower than in their local HE sectors.

Age

It was found that the discipline of education had an older staff composition than that of the UK HE sector. The largest proportions of staff employed in education were in the 46 to 60 age-group. Most staff in Northern Ireland and Wales were between age 46 and 55, while in England, the largest proportion was age 56 to 60. In Scotland, staff were employed across the age bands.

Religious belief

The majority of reporting was 'information refused' or 'no religion and not available' under religious belief. Significantly higher proportions of staff in education were recorded as Christian compared with the proportions in the UK HE sector. There were lower proportions of staff recorded as Buddhist, Hindu, Jewish, Muslim, Sikh or 'spiritual and other' in education than those of the UK HE sector.

Wales had the largest proportion of education staff recorded as Christian, at proportions higher than those of its local HE sector. Scotland had the largest proportion of staff with religious beliefs recorded as Buddhist, Hindu, Jewish, Muslim, Sikh, and 'spiritual and other'. However, the proportion of education staff in this category was lower than the proportions in Scotland's local HE sector.

Disability

In general, the reporting patterns were similar in education to that of the UK HE sector. In education, the reporting of 'known disability' increased over the period studied. There was a slightly higher proportion of 'known disability' in those recorded as BAME in education than the proportion in the UK HE sector. Different proportions of reported known disability were observed in certain age bands. For instance, there were higher proportions reported by staff in the age bands of 25 and younger.

Consistently higher proportions of known disability were recorded in education in England, with some differences across the age bands. The proportions were all higher than those of its local HE sector. In Northern Ireland, the highest proportion of known disability was in the 51 to 60 age-group.

RECOMMENDING FURTHER RESEARCH

This report equips those invested in academic staff composition and employment conditions in higher education with objective analysis of HESA data as evidence on which to base their advocacy to address structural inequalities in the discipline of education.

The findings provide snapshots of the state of the discipline during the period of 2015-2020. Because the study was informed by quantitative data, the report cannot provide insights into the *qualitative experiences* of staff within education, nor understandings of *why* this is the state of the composition nor employment conditions. Thus the discussion provided in this report brings current scholarship of UK HE into proximity with the study findings. Cognisant of such limitations, and the gaps that were identified during the exploration of the datasets, recommendations for further research are provided.

Glossary and acronyms

Most of the terms adopted within this report are those defined by the UK Higher Education Statistics Agency (HESA) or the Office for Students.¹ Terms to categorise social groups are those used in UK equality legislation, which is discussed in the ‘methodological notes’ section.

Academic employment function

‘Academic employment function’ is a HESA term which includes ‘teaching and research’, ‘teaching only’, ‘research only’ and ‘neither teaching nor research’. It defines the contract of employment and not necessarily the actual work undertaken. For instance, those whose contract of employment is ‘research only’ will have their primary academic employment function as research, even though up to six hours per week (or pro-rata for part-time staff) may be undertaken.

Attainment

The Office for Students uses ‘attainment’ when referring to the promotion of staff. Note that when it comes to a higher level of employment, this is referred to as ‘progression’, as outlined below.

Cost centre

The term ‘cost centre’ is used as a proxy for academic departments in HESA data primarily as a financial reporting tool. When the data for all the UK cost centres are combined, this is referred to as ‘UK HE sector’ in this report. When the data of all the cost centres in a specific devolved nation are combined, this is referred to as the ‘local HE sector’.

Devolved nation

The United Kingdom (UK) is composed of England, Northern Ireland, Scotland and Wales, with aspects of each context’s governance devolved in jurisdiction. The term ‘devolved nation’ is used in this report to specify each context when relevant. ‘Region’ may be preferred terminology for some in Northern Ireland, because of that context’s relation to both the UK and the Republic of Ireland. However, when referring to higher education (HE) matters, that term is most commonly used to refer to various groupings of parts of the devolved nations into regions.

FPE and FTE

HESA differentiates between what it terms ‘full person equivalents’ (FPE) and ‘full time equivalents’ (FTE). The former can be likened to a ‘head count’, measuring the various contracts and modes that a single staff member may hold. FTE is the sum of the proportions of time of a contract over the reporting period.

¹ <https://www.hesa.ac.uk/definitions/glossary>;
<https://www.hesa.ac.uk/support/definitions/staff>;
<https://www.officeforstudents.org.uk/publications/office-for-students-notifications/glossary-of-key-words-and-phrases/>

Mode of employment

‘Mode of employment’ differentiates whether staff are contracted to work part-time or full-time. The latter definition by HESA includes contracts which may be whole or part of the duration of the academic year. Part-time amounts may be misinterpreted because they include those employed on part-time contracts that add up to one FTE. When it comes to data about employment, FPE indicates those who hold a full-time contract.

Progression

For data about those staff employed at a higher level, such as professors and senior management, the study used the terminology of the Office for Students, which is ‘progression’.

Professor

In the UK, the term ‘professor’ delineates the highest academic appointment in HE for those in assigned intellectual leadership positions at a disciplinary level, who may not have departmental ‘line management’ responsibilities. HESA terms ‘professor’ a member of staff holding a level of contract which aligns with the Universities and Colleges Employers Association (UCEA) contract level 5A ‘professor’. HESA notes that the numbers in the dataset are likely an undercount, as some may have been assigned to senior administrative levels.

Leaver

A ‘leaver’ is a term for a person (FPE) who ceases to be employed. They are identified in a given year when no subsequent instance of that member of staff exists in the span of the data. Thus, no leavers could be identified in the last year provided in the dataset (that is 2019-20). This population was a distinct set that could have been analysed by year or overall. The data allowed exploration of attrition in education and the UK HE sector. Reported reasons for leaving were included in the set.

Starter

The term ‘starter’ is used by HESA to identify ‘members of staff who did not hold an academic contract of employment on 1 December in the previous reporting period but held one on 1 December in the current reporting period’. In the set provided, such staff (FPE) were identified when there was no prior instance of that member of staff over the span of the data. As 2015 was the first year in the span of the data, no difference could be noted. Thus, starters were those new staff who gained access to the UK HE sector between 2016 and 2020.

Terms of employment

‘Terms of employment’ describe the types of contract a member of staff holds at an HE institution at the date the data were returned to HESA, or at the date of the employment ceasing. Permanent or open-ended terms of employment refer to those staff employed on a contract that is permanent or has no predetermined end date officiated. This includes staff employed term-time only and staff employed on an open-ended contract. Fixed-term contract staff are those employed for a fixed period or with an end date on their contract of employment. This includes staff on rolling fixed-term contracts.

1. Introduction

1.1 RESEARCHING EQUALITY IN HIGHER EDUCATION

The staff composition in higher education (HE) is often relegated to matters of compliance with regulation, rather than seen as a subject worthy of academic study. However, quantitative measures of staff composition can provide useful indications of staff access to and participation in HE, and as such provide indications of the conditions of academic freedom. Because the conditions of academic freedom are often conceptualised as being about relations between the university and external constituencies (Abdel Latif, 2014; Karran & Mallinson, 2017; Lyer & Suba, 2019), the impact of relations among the university's own internal constituencies, *particularly within the disciplines*, remains underexplored within (higher) education research. It has, however, been a concerted concern for equality, and addressing exclusion and marginalisation has long been voiced by scholars in the Global South and excluded North (BIPOC Caucus, 2021; Sall, 1997; Zeleza, 2003).

Critical scholarship of HE has moved beyond deficit discourses about those under-represented (O'Shea et al., 2016) and limiting enquiry and action to individualised aspects of misconduct (Ahmed, 2012; Bull & Page, 2022). Instead, recent UK-based research has considered socio-cultural and structural dynamics within HE (Rollock, 2021); awarding inequalities in the research landscape (UKRI, 2020, 2021); and authorship, the canon, counter-spaces and decolonisation (Arday et al., 2021; Charteris et al., 2017; Liyanage, 2020).

There is a small but growing scholarship about access and participation when it comes to internal and international migration of academics (Pustelnikovaite, 2021; Pustelnikovaite & Chillas, 2022; Tzanakou & Henderson, 2021) with some indications that specific disciplinary conditions may affect migrant academics' participation (Siems, 2021). There has been critical study of that which falls within the practice of 'equality', 'diversity', and 'inclusion' (Cox, 2017; Doharty et al., 2021; Henderson, 2019; Pilkington, 2020). In addition to this, there have been recent studies focused on the disciplines in the UK. Some examples include sociology (Joseph-Salisbury et al., 2020), chemistry (Royal Society of Chemistry, 2022), history (Atkinson et al., 2018), politics and international relations (Hanretty, 2021), business and management (Sliwa et al., 2021) and gerontology (Bernard et al., 2022).

As the discipline of education often extols ideals of equality and the common good, and is positioned as potentially transformative by scholars, practitioners and policymakers alike, it is important to question whether the discipline within the UK embodies and enacts the principles espoused. A recent systematic scoping review, commissioned by BERA, noted the lack of attention in education research to the subject of so-called 'non-traditional academics'. The review found that only one study considered ethnic minorities; none were about disability nor those who identify as LGBTQ+; very few were about female staff; and there was a dearth of studies about research activity in contexts of the UK beyond England (Scotland n=13, Wales n=4, Northern Ireland n=2) (Boyle et al., 2021).

To contribute further to studies about in/equality, BERA commissioned this study to explore staff composition and employment conditions within education in UK HE.

1.2 CONCEPTUALISING AND DEFINING WHAT FALLS WITHIN EQUALITY

Equality, as both principle and practice, is necessary to achieve the common good. There are broad and differing conceptions of both equality and inequality. The UK HE sectors are guided by governmental regulatory frameworks as outlined briefly in this section.

In England, Scotland and Wales, public institutions are regulated by the Equality Act 2010 and the Public Sector Equality Duty. The excerpt below relates:

The broad purpose of the equality duty is to integrate consideration of equality and good relations into the day-to-day business of public authorities. If you do not consider how a function can affect different groups in different ways, it is unlikely to have the intended effect. This can contribute to greater inequality and poor outcomes. The general equality duty therefore requires organisations to consider how they could positively contribute to the advancement of equality and good relations. It requires equality considerations to be reflected into the design of policies and the delivery of services, including internal policies, and for these issues to be kept under review.

Public Sector Equality Duty/Equality and Human Rights Commission, 2011

Within that framework, specific markers are identified as legally protected in the devolved nations:

The equality duty in these nations covers the nine protected characteristics: age, disability, gender reassignment, pregnancy and maternity, race, religion or belief, sex and sexual orientation. Within Northern Ireland, these are defined as age; disability; gender reassignment; marriage and civil partnership; pregnancy and maternity; race; religion or belief; sex; sexual orientation.

Public Sector Equality Duty/Equality and Human Rights Commission, 2011

Northern Ireland is regulated through The Fair Employment and Treatment (Northern Ireland) Order 1998 (Northern Ireland Legislature, n.d.). An underpinning concern, in that context, is the management of ethno-political discrimination of those located by 'Catholic' or 'Protestant' 'community backgrounds'. However, critiques have arisen about the

significant gaps between equality law in Great Britain (GB) and Northern Ireland (NI); gaps which have widened following the introduction of single equality legislation – the Equality Act 2010 – in Great Britain. These differences mean that in a number of key areas, individuals in Northern Ireland have less protection against discrimination and harassment than people in other parts of the United Kingdom.

Equality Commission of Northern Ireland, n.d.

In this study, the researchers made decisions about the selection of ‘characteristics’ for analysis. These selections were cognisant of, though not determined by, the foci of governmental regulation and practitioner responses in the UK HE sector. This is because, when it comes to equality regulation in HE, scholars have pointed out the exploitation by institutions of perverse incentives within policies. When it comes to employment data, numbers games can be played when representing the staff composition and the conditions of their employment in ways which avoid identifying inequalities and addressing structural change. For instance, Baltaru (2019) considered institutional responses to prior legislation by analysed annual longitudinal data from 2003 to 2011 from 109 UK universities. To appear to meet the requirements of ‘demographic inclusion’ for ethnicity and disability, institutions had increased those demographics within their professional staff rather than their academic staff.

The terminology used within UK legislation to classify people into social categories has been, for the most part, adopted in this report. This was both to hold the discipline to account against its legal referents, and for the purposes of communication by BERA as a UK-based learned organisation to its primarily UK-based readership. However, throughout the report, phrasing such as ‘recorded’ and ‘categorised’ make explicit that such constructions are imposed. Refer to the methodological section for more about such decisions.

1.3 AIMS AND OBJECTIVES

The research design was informed by the BERA call to tender, discussions with the BERA council, the scholarship and expertise of the research team, and the scoping review of prior research activity (Boyle et al., 2021).

The aim of the study was to explore available statistical data to map the staff composition and employment conditions in the discipline of education in UK HE, and to identify indications of the differential impact of conditions on those located by age, sex, ethnicity, disability, religious beliefs and nationality. Patterns of improvement or deterioration in equality were studied across education in the UK and in each of the devolved nations of England, Northern Ireland, Scotland and Wales.

Objectives of the study were to:

1. Investigate empirical datasets about the staff composition and career trajectories within education across all UK HE, and specific to England, Scotland, Northern Ireland and Wales.
2. Map changing demographics in a five-year period through descriptive analysis of differentiated data of sex, ethnicity, religious belief, known dis/ability, age, nationality and their intersections.
3. Identify indicators of social dis/advantage on academics’ careers in education in terms of contract type, retention, attainment, progression and assigned senior leadership.

1.4 THE STRUCTURE OF THE REPORT

In the next section, the methodology is outlined. This is followed by the findings, which are presented with infographics of the visualised data and in brief written narrative form. Informed by those findings, the authors discuss highlighted findings, and bring concerns into proximity with relevant literature. The report sets out recommendations for further research.

2. Methodology

This study explored existing statistical data relating to academic staff in the discipline of education employed at HE institutions in the UK. Such data are reported by institutions to the Higher Education Statistics Agency (HESA), which is the body which collects and curates data on HE.

2.1 SELECTION AND GROUPING OF DATASETS

Academic disciplines of HE within HESA sets are categorised as ‘cost centres’. Unrounded tailored HESA² datasets on the cost centre ‘135 Education’, combined data for all UK cost centres (hereafter ‘UK HE sector’) and the combined data of each devolved nation (hereafter the ‘local HE sector’) were purchased from Jisc. The period under study was inclusive of five academic years – from 2015-16 to 2019-20. Data were requested about staff composition for age, sex, ethnicity, disability, religious beliefs and nationality. The study did not ask questions about socio-economic class, gender nor sexual orientation, so no such data were purchased. Data were requested about employment conditions, including the academic employment function, contract function, mode of employment, terms of employment, starters, leavers, attainment and progression.

Figure 1 (pages 20–21) outlines how the components of the data were grouped. The vertical axis outlines the grouped components for the age, sex, ethnicity, nationality, disability and religious belief of academic staff. The horizontal axis outlines how the data about staff employment were grouped. Within Figure 1, clear indications are provided about the appropriate data range of each set, and whether the sets were of ‘full person equivalents’ (FPE) and ‘full time equivalents’ (FTE). The possibilities of analysis were limited by the ways in which the data are recorded by HE institutions and then curated by HESA, and gaps in the completeness of those data. In addition, the researchers were not provided with access to all items requested and, for some data, not at the granularity required. The limitations are outlined below and where relevant.

2 Copyright Higher Education Statistics Agency Limited 2021. Neither the Higher Education Statistics Agency Limited nor HESA Services Limited can accept responsibility for any inferences or conclusions derived by third parties from data or other information supplied by the Higher Education Statistics Agency Limited or HESA Services Limited.

2.1.1 Sex

The recording of sex allowed by HESA is 'male', 'female' and 'other'. The justification provided is that both recommendation and regulation informed the options for the recording of data related to sex:

This field records the sex of the member of staff, as opposed to the gender with which they identify. Other is included for staff whose sex aligns with terms such as intersex, androgyne, intergender, ambigender, gender fluid, polygender and gender queer. The specification of this field is based on the Recommendations on monitoring from ECU (Equality Challenge Unit). HESA does not, however, include a 'prefer not to say' option. Prior to 2017/18, the legal sex of the member of staff was used.³

The recording of 'other' commenced as a category in 2017. In the datasets provided, amounts for 'other' were recorded in the local HE sectors of England, Scotland and Wales, but not in Northern Ireland. In education, only in England were there staff recorded as 'other'.

For this characteristic, there were no 'unknowns' recorded, as 'due to the requirement to return this information to HM Revenue & Customs, legal sex information will be known for all staff'.⁴

2.1.2 Ethnicity

Representations of ethnicity by UK statistical governmentality, such as that adopted by HESA, are contested in the UK. Objections raised by society and by scholars from across the disciplines were renewed during Covid-19, with a plethora of articles problematising the racialised grouping of heterogeneous peoples into 'black, Asian, minority ethnic' (commonly termed BAME) which also excludes disadvantaged minorities such as Gypsies, Travellers and Roma who are recorded as 'white' (Khunti et al., 2020). In Aspinall's (2020, p. 1) study of the genealogies and etymologies of such categorisations, it is argued that

Commonly used acronyms are little understood in the wider society, are confusing, and of limited acceptability to those they describe, while other collective terms are offensive and ethnocentric. Accurate description is recommended to delineate ethnic minority populations in terms of their constituent groups.

HESA limits the collecting of data on ethnicity to 24 categories. Two sets were provided for this study, grouped as in Figure 1. The 'not known' category (including 'not known', 'not available' and 'information refused') in education comprised a sizeable proportion of the data.

3 <https://www.hesa.ac.uk/support/definitions/staff>

4 <https://www.hesa.ac.uk/support/definitions/staff>

Population restricted to: 2015-16 to 2019-20 Category 1 academic staff All cost centres including education										
2015-2020 FPE 2015-2020 FTE 2016-2020 FPE 2015-2019 FPE		Academic staff	Academic employment function	Academic contract function	Mode of employment	Terms of employment	Starters	Leavers	Attainment and progression	Region of provider
			research only/ teaching & research/ teaching only/ other	junior/senior/ professor/ senior management	part-time/ full-time	fixed-term/ open-ended				
Age	25 and under, 26–30, 31–35, 36–40, 41–45, 46–50, 51–55, 56–60, 61–65, 66 and over	2015-2020 FPE								2015-2020 FPE
		2015-2020 FTE	2015-2020 FTE	2015-2020 FTE	2015-2020 FTE	2015-2020 FTE	2016-2020 FPE	2015-2019 FPE	2016-2020 FPE	2015-2020 FTE
Sex	male, female, other, unknown	2015-2020 FPE								2015-2020 FPE
		2015-2020 FTE						2015-2019 FPE	2016-2020 FPE	2015-2020 FTE
	male, female	2015-2020 FPE								2015-2020 FPE
		2015-2020 FTE	2015-2020 FTE	2015-2020 FTE	2015-2020 FTE	2015-2020 FTE	2016-2020 FPE	2015-2019 FPE	2016-2020 FPE	2015-2020 FTE
Ethnicity	white, BAME, other, unknown	2015-2020 FPE								2015-2020 FPE
		2015-2020 FTE	2015-2020 FTE	2015-2020 FTE	2015-2020 FTE	2015-2020 FTE	2016-2020 FPE	2015-2019 FPE	2016-2020 FPE	2015-2020 FTE

Figure 1: Detail about the tailored dataset and groupings for this study

Population restricted to: 2015-16 to 2019-20 Category 1 academic staff All cost centres including education										
2015-2020 FPE 2015-2020 FTE 2016-2020 FPE 2015-2019 FPE		Academic staff	Academic employment function	Academic contract function	Mode of employment	Terms of employment	Starters	Leavers	Attainment and progression	Region of provider
			research only/ teaching & research/ teaching only/ other	junior/senior/ professor/ senior management	part-time/ full-time	fixed-term/ open-ended				
	white, black–Caribbean, black–African, other black background, Asian–Indian, Asian–Pakistani, Asian–Bangladeshi, Chinese, other Asian background, mixed, other, unknown	2015-2020 FPE	2015-2020 FTE	2015-2020 FTE	2015-2020 FTE	2015-2020 FTE		2015-2019 FPE	2016-2020 FPE	2015-2020 FPE
		2015-2020 FTE								2015-2020 FTE
Disability	known disability, no known disability, unknown	2015-2020 FPE	2015-2020 FTE	2015-2020 FTE	2015-2020 FTE	2015-2020 FTE	2016-2020 FPE	2015-2019 FPE	2016-2020 FPE	2015-2020 FPE
		2015-2020 FTE								2015-2020 FTE

Figure 1: Detail about the tailored dataset and groupings for this study

2.1.3 Disability

In UK HE, staff are not required to report a disability. Reported disabilities are those self-reported by staff. HESA allows for the recording of 11 entries. However, the dataset provided by HESA did not allow for exploration of types of disability.

2.1.4 Religious belief

HESA allows 15 options to record religious belief. A limitation of this analysis was HESA's requirement that categories of religious belief be grouped in the set provided. The seven available categories of 'Christian' were grouped into one, which limited analysis central to the Equality Act of Northern Ireland. Other religious beliefs and faiths were also grouped, as in Figure 1. This disallowed probing of the data in response to questions raised by scholars about anti-Semitism and Islamophobia in the UK academy (for more see Ahmed, 2007; Akel, 2021; Brown & Saeed, 2015; Gholami, 2021; Guest et al., 2020; Ramadan, 2017).

2.1.5 Nationality

The HESA datasets categorise the nationality of education staff by UK, EU, non-UK/EU, and individual countries. HESA data reveal little about the actual national profile of staff in UK academia, an issue common to statistical data on migrants in the UK more broadly.⁵ A limitation of these data is the restriction of

reporting to one nationality per staff member. Institutions are instructed to make selections in the following manner:

Where staff have a dual nationality including British, they should be coded as British. If a dual nationality, not including British, but including non-UK EU country then use relevant EU country code. If neither British or non-UK EU country then code as either nationality.

HESA, 2020

Information is thereby excluded about those who hold more than one nationality, which limits analysis of dis/advantage relating to nationality.

To explore how the staff composition reflects global inequality, the researchers decided to code countries of primary nationality according to World Bank Country and Lending Groups country classification of high-, upper-middle, lower-middle and low-income.⁶ This provided a framework for analysing patterns of access between the 'Global North' (or 'minority world') and the 'Global South' (or 'majority world').⁷

5 See for instance <https://migrationobservatory.ox.ac.uk/resources/briefings/who-counts-as-a-migrant-definitions-and-their-consequences/>

6 <https://datahelpdesk.worldbank.org/knowledgebase/articles/906519>

7 These terms were advocated by Alam (2008) to problematise existing terms and 'the anomaly that the Group of 8 countries—whose decisions affect majority of the world's peoples—represent a tiny fraction of humankind' (p. 89) and to challenge the Western rhetoric of democracy. The term 'majority world' is an affirmation of community of the majority of the world.

2.2 APPROACH TO ANALYSIS AND REPORTING

The datasets were synthesised and then verified for quality and validity against HESA publicly available datasets. During analyses, they were explored by generating and comparing tables and figures to understand the differences and relationships between groupings. Informed by ethical principles, including that of balance and justice, the set was approached from the different entry points (such as sex or ethnicity). This is reflected in the structure of reporting. For each entry point, percentages were outlined, and proportions of each characteristic and intersecting characteristics considered, in addition to differences and rates of change over time. The study considered how these proportions and patterns in education compared to that of the whole UK HE sector and the local HE sectors. To assist future researchers with sufficient detail, a study description and replication checklist⁸ was constructed (see Appendix: Description and replication checklist). The researchers hope that the checklist will assist fellow researchers using HESA data to overcome challenges encountered during this study.

The study did not use benchmarks nor targets for the realisation of equality. Rather, it made comparisons with other groupings and characteristics; the whole UK HE sector; and each of the local HE sectors in the devolved nations. This is because the devolved nations differ in size, histories, local demographics and regulatory frameworks. The intention was for proportions and patterns to be identified and presented in ways credible and accessible to readers, while bringing attention to inequalities, under-representation and omission in the data.

Queen's University Belfast awarded ethical clearance (REF: 036_2122). Data handling and presentation adhered to the 'Five Safes' framework as outlined by the Secure Research Service (SRS),⁹ and the requirements made by HESA. As such, in this report no unrounded numbers are presented nor exact numbers of the sample sizes ('N') to mitigate the risk of possible identification if the small numbers involved in the study were compared to publicly available datasets. For consistency percentages were used, with the less than (<) or more than (>) signs to explicitly indicate where these are rounded. In addition, these representations are aggregated, either across the UK or within each devolved nation, and without reference to individual institutions or institutional types.

8 The format of this checklist is adapted from the TiDIER template, which is more typical in medical and education randomised control trials (Hoffmann et al., 2014). The Template for Intervention Description and Replication (TiDIER) was developed by international researchers and stakeholders as a standardised guide to improve reporting and replicability of research and interventions. It is a 12-item checklist with guidance information for good reporting. For more see <http://www.consort-statement.org/resources/tidier-2>

9 <https://www.ons.gov.uk/aboutus/whatwedo/statistics/requestingstatistics/approvedresearcherscheme#the-five-safes>

3. Findings

The findings are presented in visual and narrative form. Readers are encouraged to consider the infographics alongside their reading of the findings within each sub-section.

This section has two parts. Part A presents findings about the state of equality in academic staff composition in education departments in UK HE. To contextualise, it begins by presenting findings about the general employment conditions within education important for equality, and compares these with the UK HE sector. The analysis considered both FPE and FTE statistics. These are included in the reporting when significantly different. The findings from reported data on age, sex, ethnicity, disability, religious belief and nationality are outlined in separate sub-sections. These begin with the proportions of each characteristic in general in the UK HE sector and in education; findings related to that characteristic in education; and findings from exploring intersections with other characteristics in education. This is then followed by findings about employment conditions, positions of attainment, and progression. While not without limitations, FPE statistics inform the findings of the first sub-section about staff composition to show *who* has been given access to employment in education, while FTE statistics inform the findings about employment conditions to show *how* they were employed. Part B outlines findings from exploring FPE statistics about those given access to employment ('starters'); those who achieved attainment and progression; and attrition ('leavers') in education.

3.1 PART A: ACADEMIC STAFF COMPOSITION

The proportions of staff in education varied considerably across the devolved nations. In 2020, England had the largest proportion of staff (83% FPE) in education, then Scotland (10.5% FPE), Wales (>4% FPE) and Northern Ireland (2% FPE). Over the period studied, increased FPE proportions were notable for Scotland only (from >7% FPE in 2015).

In the period 2015–20, there was a considerably lower growth rate in staff employed in education (<1% FTE) when compared to the growth rate for the UK HE sector as a whole (9.5% FTE). This is a concern for the discipline. It should be kept in mind when reading of the lower comparable growth rate in education when contrasted with all UK cost centres.

The study considered the proportions of staff employed in the academic functions of ‘teaching and research’, ‘teaching only’ or ‘research only’. The largest proportion in education was in ‘teaching and research’ (>47% FPE; <59% FTE). This was a slightly higher proportion than that of the UK HE sector (<44% FPE; <52% FTE). The proportion for ‘teaching and research’ in education had shrunk by a difference of 10% in the five-year period. The only notable growth was the proportion of academic staff in ‘teaching only’ contracts (<47% from <38% FPE; >34% from 24% FTE).

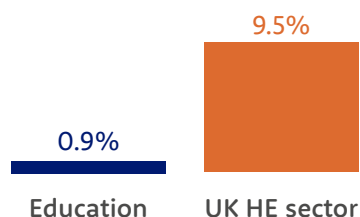
Education had lower proportions of staff FPE who were on ‘research only’ contracts. In 2015, education had >5% of staff in ‘research only’ contracts in comparison to the UK HE sector at >24%. This pattern did not change significantly over the five-year period, with a slight growth to <6% in education, a lower proportion than that of the UK HE sector (>23%). When considered by FTE, the proportion of staff holding ‘research only’ contracts was 6.5% compared to 27% in the UK HE sector. When functions for research (that is ‘research only’ and ‘teaching and research’) are combined, only two-thirds (66% FTE) were recorded in education compared to a higher proportion in the UK HE sector (79%).

Education had more staff at senior levels than junior. This was most extreme when considered by FTE, in which 73% of staff were employed in senior contracts in education compared to 59% in the UK HE sector. Yet lower proportions of education staff progressed to professorship (<7% FPE) than in the UK HE sector (>11% FPE).

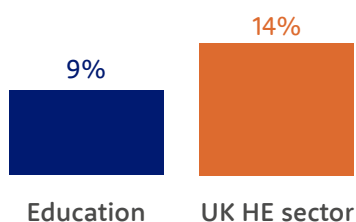
Compared to the UK HE sector, education had a higher proportion of those on permanent contracts. The proportion of fixed-term contracts in education decreased over the five-year period to >15% in 2020. For those in junior levels, the awarding of permanent FTE contracts improved by 11%, to 85% in 2020. The proportion of staff who gained access to education (that is FPE) through part-time contracts (48%) was also higher compared to the UK HE sector (34%).

General conditions of employment in education in UK HE (FTE)

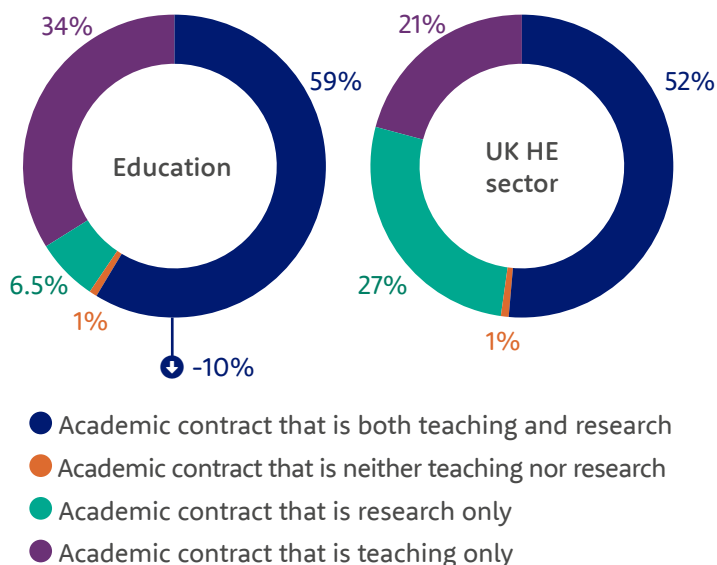
Growth rates in academic staff employment (2015-20)



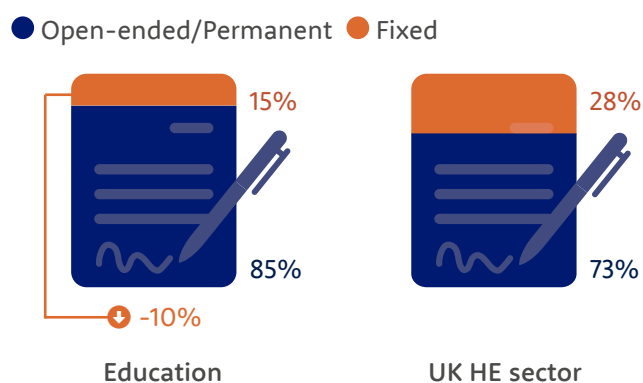
Growth rate of professors (2015-20)



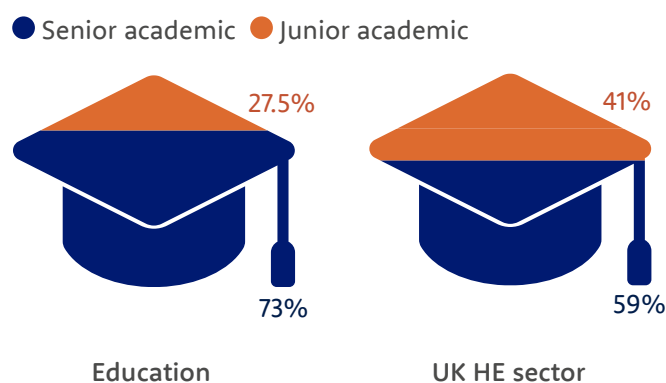
Academic employment function proportions (2019-20)



Terms of employment proportions (2019-20)

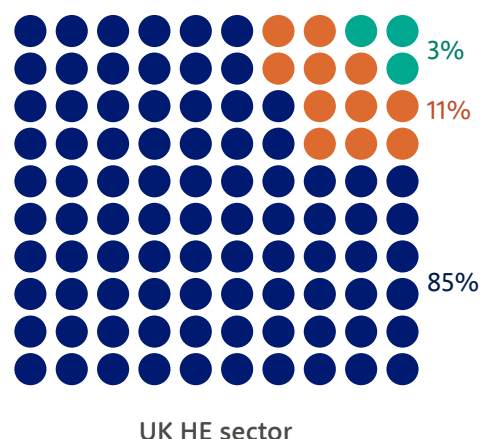
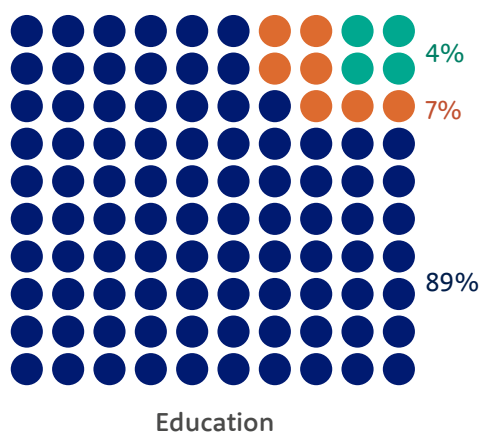


Level: Junior/senior proportions (2019-20)



Assigned leadership: Professor and senior management proportions (FPE; 2019-20)

Other contract level Professor Senior management



Findings of Belluigi, Arday and O'Keeffe (2023) informed by HESA statistical data

3.1.1 Age

The data about education staff were analysed according to age. This is reported first because it was found to have intersectional importance relevant to some of the sub-sections below. The infographic shows the age-spread of staff employed across the UK HE sector, and how that differs from the discipline of education.

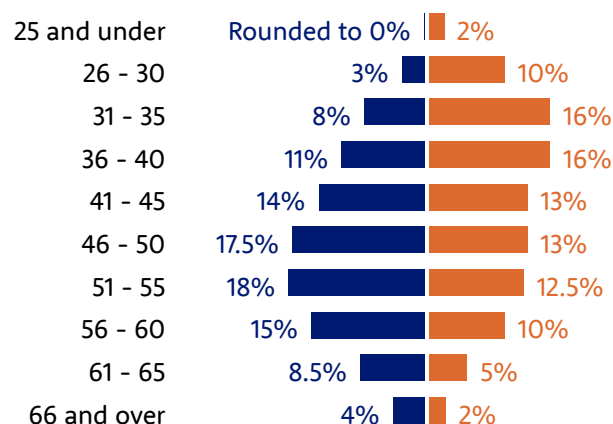
The staff composition in education was considerably older than that in the UK HE sector. The largest proportions were between age 46 and 60 in education, compared to the UK HE sector in which the largest proportions were between 31 and 40. Differences emerged in the devolved nations. Scotland had a more even spread of staff across the age groups, Northern Ireland and Wales had most staff between age 46 and 55, with England having the highest proportion between age 51 and 55.

The intersection of age with sex was a notable finding. In education, there were higher proportions of younger than older female staff, and higher proportions of older than younger male staff. Indications were that, as staff aged, the proportion of female staff decreased and the proportion of male staff increased; and with seniority, professorships and senior management contracts were awarded to male staff in greater proportions. Findings related to disability and age, and the reasons for attrition and age, are reported in the sections below.

Age of academic staff in education in UK HE (FPE)

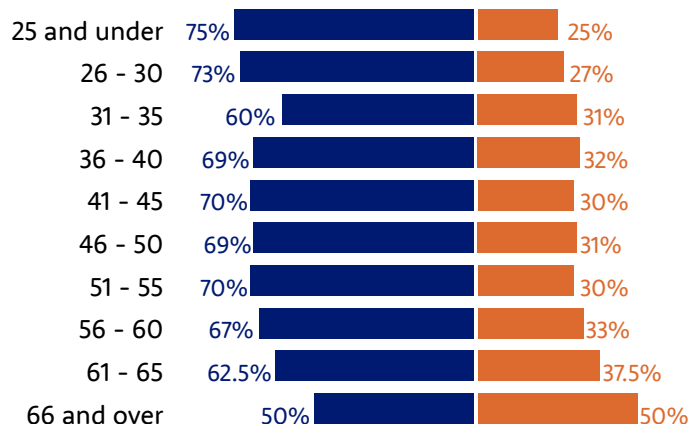
Age of education staff compared to the UK HE sector (2019-20)

● Education ● UK HE sector



Age of education staff by sex (2019-20)

● Female ● Male



3.1.2 Sex

Sex and staff composition

Across the UK HE sector in 2020, there were slightly lower proportions of female staff (47%) than male staff (53%). Education had a consistently higher percentage of female staff than in the UK HE sector, with slight increases over the period studied in each of the devolved nations. The percentage composition of 'sex' in UK education in 2020 was 69% recorded as female, 31% recorded as male and >0% recorded as other. England was the only nation to return values of 'other' in education. As such, this report discusses the first two categories.

The highest proportion of female staff in education was in Wales (70%), consistent with its local HE sector which had the highest proportion of female staff (>47%) of the devolved nations. The lowest proportion in education was in Northern Ireland (<64%), which too was consistent with its local HE sector, which employed the lowest proportion of female staff in the UK (44%).

There were generally more female staff than male staff in education. This was similar to the pattern when sex was considered by ethnicity at the level of general comparison, that is when grouping those recorded as BAME and those recorded as white. However, this differed for specific groups recorded within the category of BAME, as indicated in the graphics. In this narrative, the percentage of specific groups is reported to reflect their proportions against the overall staff population and to highlight under-representation. In such small percentages that their representation would be rounded to zero, were those education staff recorded as Asian/Asian British Bangladeshi and 'other black background'. Although a very small percentage, the proportion of male

staff in those groupings was higher than that of female staff. Over the study period, the percentage of female staff recorded as Asian/Asian British Pakistani and black/black British African increased to only under <1%. More male staff were recorded as black/black British African than female staff, rounded to <2%. In all the devolved nations, there was an under-representation in education of male staff recorded as Asian/Asian British Indian, Asian/Asian British Pakistani, black/black British African, black/black British Caribbean. In particular, Northern Ireland had 0% (neither male nor female) staff recorded in those ethnic categories between 2015 and 2020.

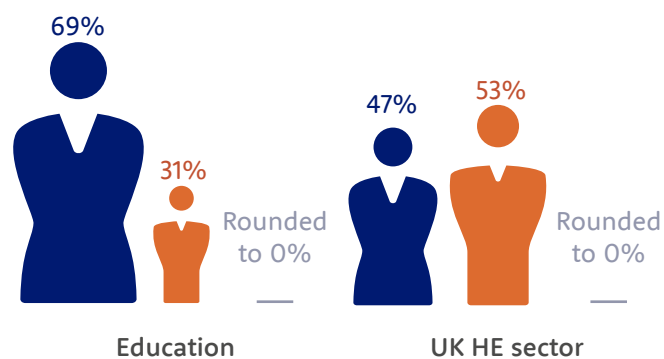
In considering the sex of staff relative to age, specific age bands in the older groups of education staff showed different proportions to the average pattern of 69% females to 31% males. For female staff, from the height of their proportions at age 25, access to employment in education decreased consistently until age 66 and over, when 50% of staff were female. Male staff followed the reverse pattern. The impact of the older staff composition generally in education, and this pattern, suggests that female staff in education had shorter career durations at senior and professorial level than male staff. It is only from age 41 that the percentage of female staff at professor level increases. For male staff this increase is seen earlier at age 31. At age 66, the percentage of male professors in education was double that of female professors.

In considering the sex of staff relative to disability, there appeared to be no significant differences between what was reported by male and female staff. There was slightly higher reporting of known disability by female professors (6%) than male professors (<5%),

Sex of academic staff in education in UK HE

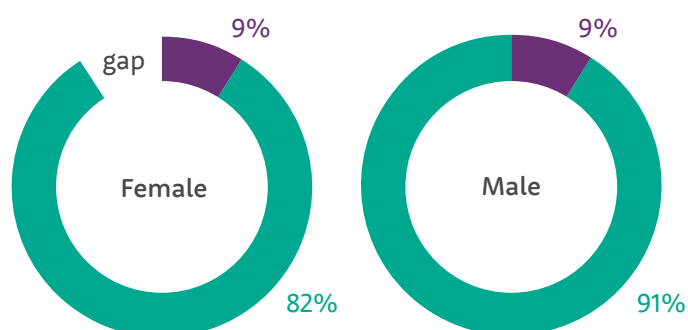
Sex of education staff compared to the UK HE sector (FPE; 2019-20)

● Female ● Male ● Other



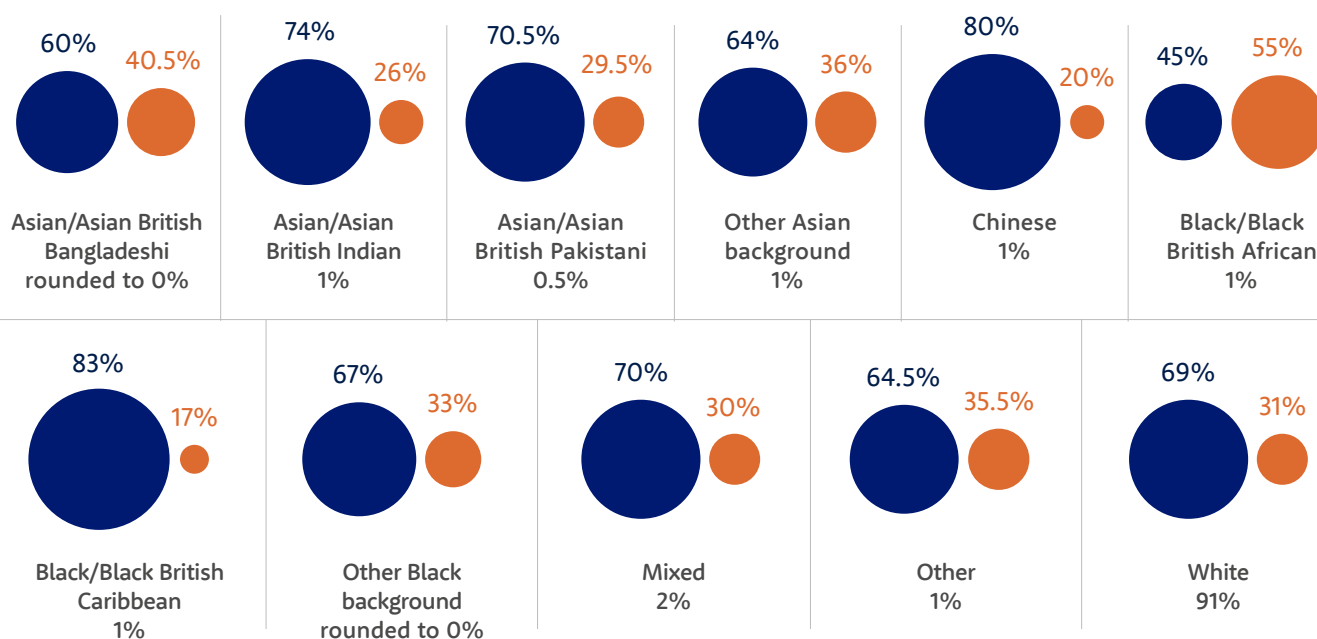
Sex with ethnicity proportions (FPE; 2019-20)

● BAME ● White



Differentiated BAME data with sex proportions (FTE; 2019-20)

● Female ● Male



and higher reporting by male staff in senior management positions (>6% to >2% female staff). However, the small numbers limit firm conclusions. In both education and the UK HE sector, the reporting of 'unknown' for disability has improved much more in the reporting of male staff than that of female staff, with decreased percentages in that category.

Sex and employment conditions

Fixed-term contracts in education decreased between 2015 and 2020, with a slightly higher proportion of female staff employed on fixed-term contracts (<16%) than male staff (14%). When considering female employment conditions, there was a far higher proportion employed full-time (70%) than part-time (>31%). So too were male staff, but with a higher proportion than women full-time (>79%) than part-time (>21%). There was a slight increase in the employment of those working part-time, for both female and male staff, over the study period.

There were differences in proportions when considering each sex relative to academic employment function, indicating that male staff were positioned at an advantage despite their numbers being smaller in education. A large proportion of male staff were employed in 'teaching and research' contracts (62%), with lower proportions in 'teaching only' (33%) and 'research only' (5.5%) contracts. Female staff were appointed at lower proportions in 'teaching and research' (58%) contracts, with slightly higher proportions in 'teaching only' (35%) and 'research only' (7%) contracts than the proportions for male staff.

There were higher proportions of male staff FTE in senior academic positions (>76%) than junior (<24%) compared to female staff FTE (<71% senior and >29% junior). These were, in part, impacted by the mode of employment where lower proportions of staff were employed full-time than part-time at junior levels. This pattern was inverted at senior levels. Of the female staff employed at senior levels, 63% were full-time and 37% part-time. At the same level, the proportion of male staff working full-time was <73%, a difference of 10% between male and female staff. The overall FPE showed smaller gaps in proportions by sex, where of the male staff employed, a higher proportion were at senior academic level (64.8%) than junior (35.2%), and of the female staff employed, 59% were in senior positions and 41% junior.

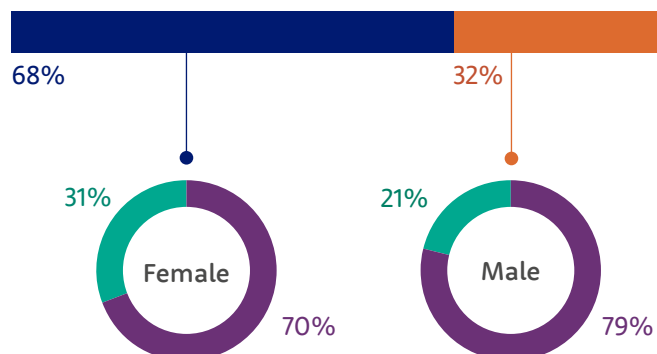
Although fewer men than women were employed in education, a higher proportion of men (>10%) than women (>5%) were working at professor level. Similarly, a slightly higher proportion of male staff (>5%) than female staff (4%) progressed to senior management level in the period studied. Mode of employment seemed to affect this. Of full-time female staff, >6% were in professorships compared with <11% of male full-time staff. Of part-time female staff in education, <3% were in professorships, compared to 8% of male part-time staff. This indicates that female staff in part-time positions at professorial level may be disadvantaged. Most female staff who progressed to senior management were in the 51 to 55 age-group, consistent with patterns in the UK HE sector. The highest proportion of male staff who progressed to senior management was in the 56 to 60 age-group, older than in the UK HE sector.

Sex of academic staff in education in UK HE

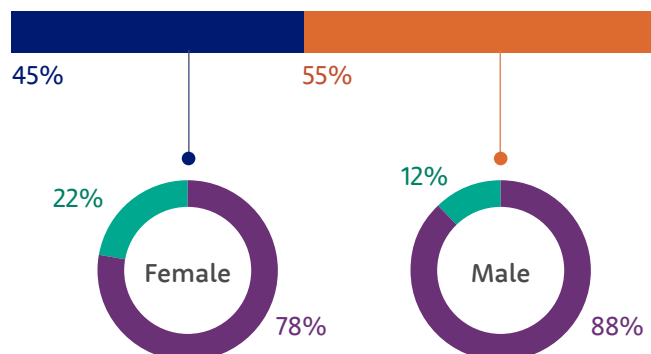
Sex with proportions of mode of employment (FTE; 2019-20)

● Female ● Male

Education



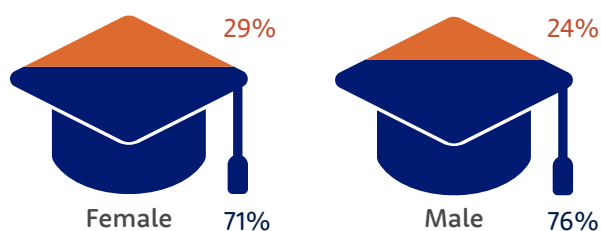
UK HE sector



● Full-time ● Part-time

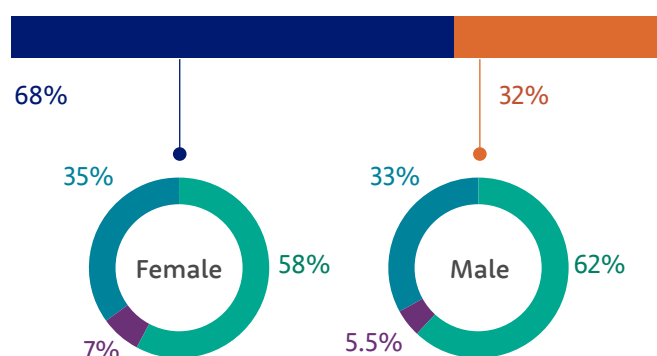
Sex with proportions of junior to senior levels (FTE; 2019-20)

● Senior academic ● Junior academic



Sex with proportions of academic employment function (FTE; 2019-20)

● Female ● Male



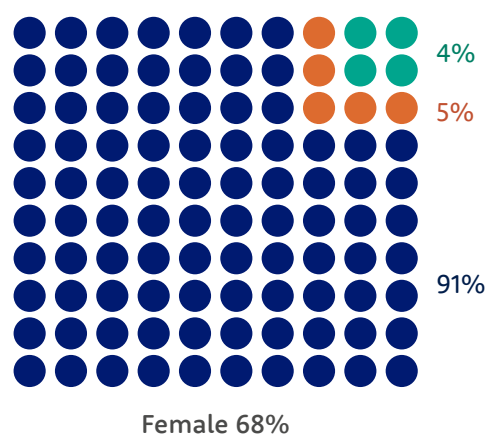
● Academic contract that is both teaching and research

● Academic contract that is research only

● Academic contract that is teaching only

Sex with proportions of contract level (FTE; 2019-20)

● Other contract level ● Professor ● Senior management



Female 68%



Male 32%

Findings of Belluigi, Arday and O'Keeffe (2023) informed by HESA statistical data

When sex is considered relative to ethnicity and professorial positions in education, certain groups were under-represented. There were no female professors in education recorded as Asian/Asian British Bangladeshi nor black/black British African during the period of study. There were <1% male professors in education recorded as black/black British African. There were <1% male professors in education recorded as Asian/Asian British Pakistani, and the percentage of female professors recorded as Asian/Asian British Pakistani was rounded to 0%.

The sex of those in professorial and senior management positions was explored by income country. Because those from high-income countries comprised the bulk of staff at these levels, that composition set the pattern of the higher proportions of progression to professor and senior manager in male groupings than in female groupings. When rounded, the proportions of female to male staff from upper-middle-income countries appeared to have similar proportions of <3% professors and >0% senior management. However, rounding masks the reality that there was slightly more male representation recorded as holding those primary nationalities.

3.1.3 Ethnicity

Ethnicity and staff composition

Across the UK HE sector in 2020, 75% of staff were recorded as white, 16.5% were recorded as BAME and 9% as unknown. In education, 85% of staff were recorded as white, 8% were recorded as BAME and 6.5% as unknown. The large percentage of the latter is of concern in the reporting of ethnicity. There may be gendered and contextual dimensions: for instance, in education, Wales had the lowest percentage of 'unknown' for ethnicity (<1% female staff; 3% male staff), and Scotland the

highest (>6% female staff; >12% male staff). The findings below are based on the known ethnicities.

Education had a higher proportion of staff recorded as white than the proportion of the UK HE sector, at a difference of >10%. In the devolved nations, the highest proportion of staff recorded as white was in Northern Ireland (99%), followed by Wales (96%), Scotland (91.5%) and England (91%). Over the study period, there was a notable and comparable improvement in the proportion of staff recorded as BAME in education (>39% growth rate) and across the UK HE sector (36% growth rate). Despite this, the proportion of education staff recorded as BAME in 2020 was still less than half the proportion recorded in the UK HE sector.

For those education staff recorded as BAME, two-fifths were recorded as Asian, one-fifth mixed and one-fifth black. Most notable was the 86% rate of growth in the proportion of those recorded as 'other' (from <11% in 2015 to >15% in 2020), which was over double the rate of increase for that category in the UK HE sector. However, over the study period, education showed a far smaller growth in employment of those recorded as black (a rate of 13.5%) than the UK HE sector (a rate of >53%), and a far smaller growth of those recorded as mixed (a rate of 26.5%) than the UK HE sector (a rate of 46.5%).

Ethnicity of academic staff in education in UK HE

Ethnicity in education compared to the UK HE sector (FPE; 2019-20)

● White ● BAME ● Unknown

Education

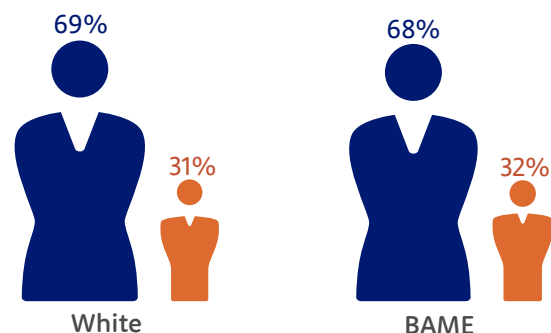


UK HE sector

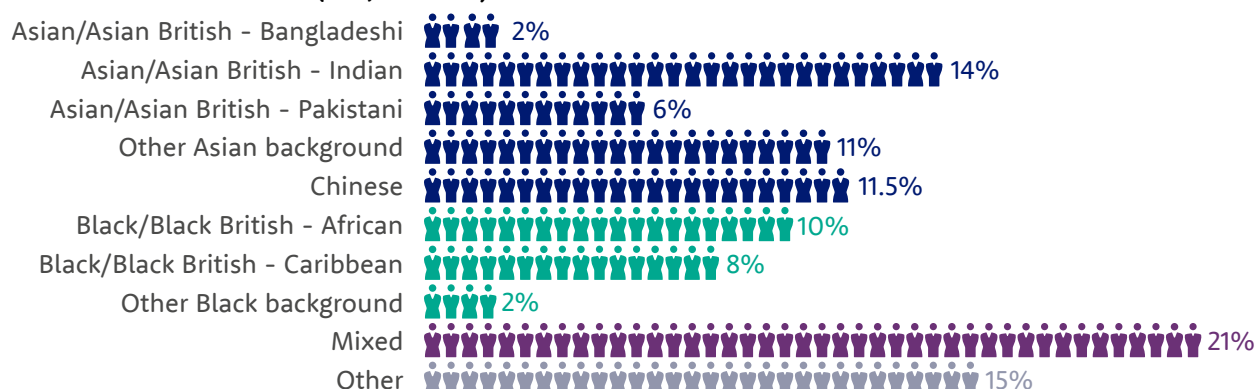


Sex proportion by ethnicity (FPE; 2019-20)

● Female ● Male



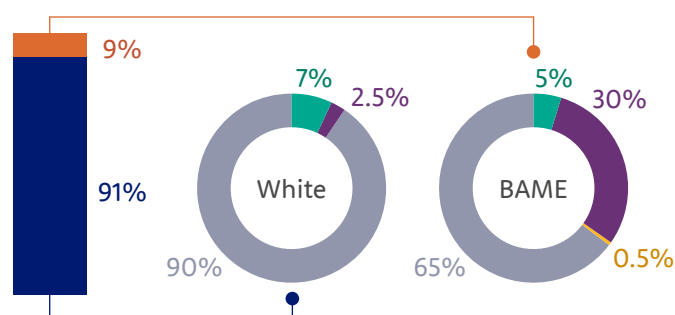
Differentiated BAME data (FPE; 2019-20)



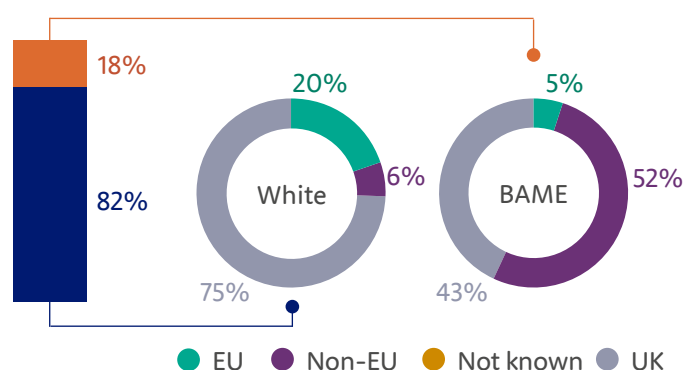
Ethnicity by grouped primary nationality (FPE; 2019-20)

● White ● BAME

Education

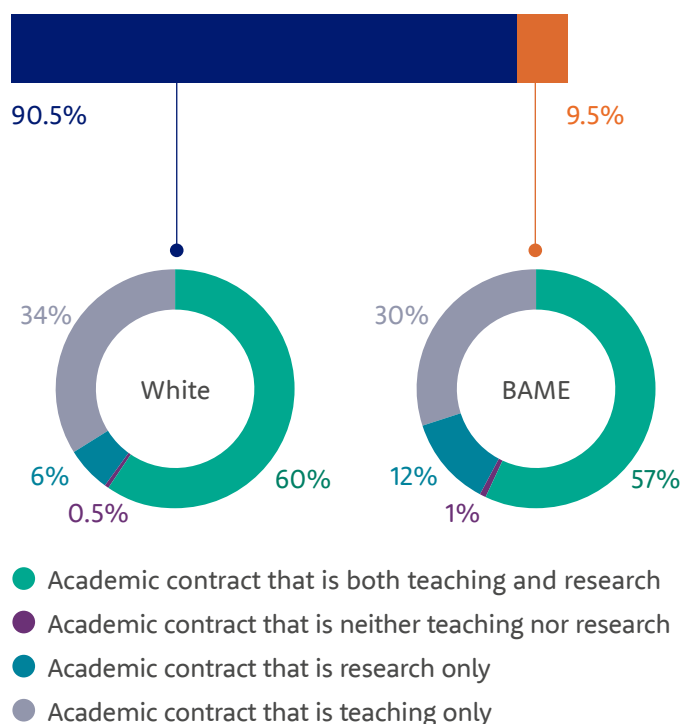


UK HE sector



Ethnicity by academic employment function (FTE; 2019-20)

● White ● BAME



Findings of Belluigi, Arday and O'Keeffe (2023) informed by HESA statistical data

In considering ethnicity relative to sex within education, there were similar patterns of females to males in both staff recorded as white and as BAME. However, education in Wales had the largest proportion of female to male staff, for those recorded as BAME (<75%: >25%) and those recorded as white (>71%: >29%). Increases were observed in both groupings over the study period. For those recorded as BAME in Northern Ireland in 2020, the proportion of female staff in education (96.5%) was higher than the proportions recorded in the local HE sector (<29.5%). However, it should be kept in mind that there were very few of Northern Ireland's education staff recorded as BAME.

Differences emerged when exploring the proportions of those recorded as BAME in more granularity in relation to sex. This should be treated with caution as the actual numbers were small and the proportion of unknown ethnicity was large (<7% of the female staff and >8% of the male staff in 2020). The patterns of proportions were similar across sex for those categorised as Asian, mixed, other black background, black/black British Caribbean and 'other' BAME. However, the proportion of black/black British African male staff (<2%) was higher than female staff (>1%). Similarly, in the UK HE sector, there was a slightly higher proportion of black/black British African male than female staff. The proportion of black/black British Caribbean female staff was <1% in education, which was double the male proportion for the same year in education: a similar pattern to the UK HE sector.

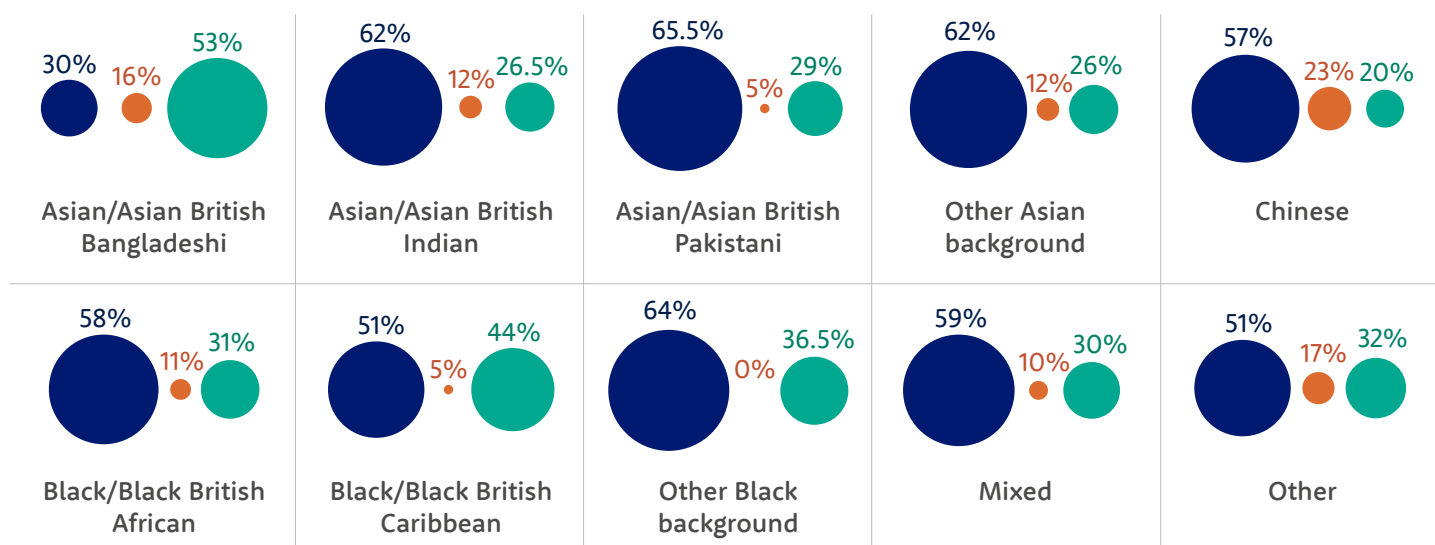
In education, those with UK primary nationality were the largest proportions of both those recorded as white and those recorded as BAME. Those proportions were higher than in the UK HE sector. Compared to the UK HE sector, of those recorded as white with UK primary nationality, there was a difference of 15%. Of those with EU primary nationalities, there was a higher proportion of those recorded as white. There was a 22% difference in proportions of staff recorded as BAME with UK primary nationality in education compared to the UK HE sector. There was considerably more global diversity among those recorded as BAME, with a higher proportion of non-EU/UK (>31%) primary nationalities than the proportion of those recorded as white (3%). A lower proportion of those recorded as BAME held EU primary nationalities (>5%).

While higher proportions of Christians were recorded in education than in the UK HE sector, there were differences according to ethnicity. A higher proportion of those recorded as white had Christian religious belief (83%). Of those recorded as BAME with religious belief, 44% were recorded as Christian (12% higher than the proportion in the UK HE sector). However, that was a lower proportion than the 56% proportion combined grouping of 'spiritual and other', Buddhist, Hindu, Jewish, Muslim, Sikh in education. Although this indicates more plurality of belief within those education staff recorded as BAME, this combined grouping in education was a lower proportion than the 68% for those recorded as BAME in the UK HE sector.

Ethnicity of academic staff in education in UK HE

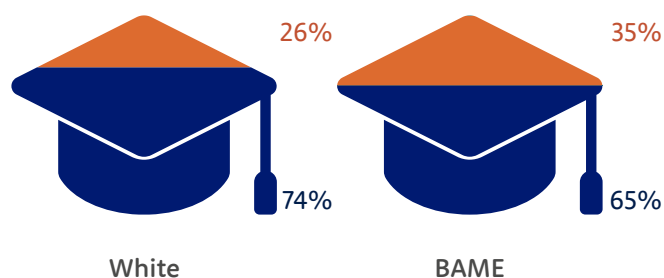
Differentiated BAME data by academic employment function (FTE; 2019-20)

- Academic contract that is both teaching and research
- Academic contract that is research only
- Academic contract that is teaching only



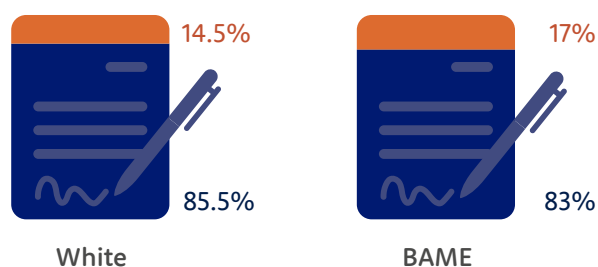
Ethnicity with proportions by academic levels (FTE; 2019-20)

- Senior academic
- Junior academic



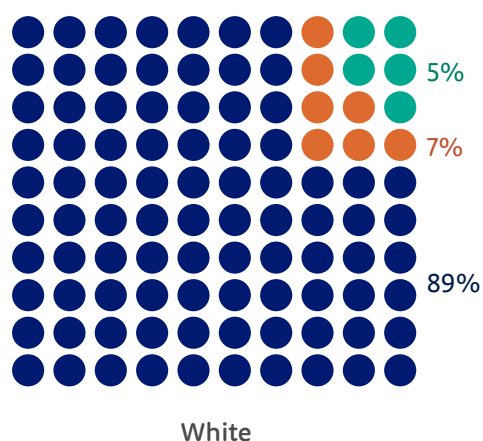
Ethnicity with proportions by terms of employment (FTE; 2019-20)

- Open-ended/Permanent
- Fixed



Contract split by ethnicity (FTE; 2019-20)

- Other contract level
- Professor
- Senior management



Findings of Belluigi, Arday and O'Keeffe (2023) informed by HESA statistical data

Ethnicity and employment conditions

There were differences observed when analysing ethnicity and proportions of FTE across junior, senior, professor and senior management levels. Proportions of staff grouped by ethnicity differed when considered by academic employment function. In 2020, staff recorded as BAME were awarded 'teaching and research' (57%), 'teaching only' (<30%) and 'research only' (>12%) contracts in different proportions to those recorded as white. There was a reduction in the proportion of 'teaching and research' contracts awarded to staff recorded as BAME – from 72% in 2015 to >57% in 2020 – at junior levels (>39% to >24%) and senior levels (>83% to 72%). Of concern is that the increased proportion for staff recorded as BAME was in 'teaching only' contracts at junior level, from 15.5% in 2015 to >30% in 2020. For staff recorded as white in 2020, higher proportions were employed in 'teaching and research' (<60%) and 'teaching only' (34%) contracts, with a lower proportion in 'research only' (<6%) contracts.

There was a greater proportion of staff recorded as BAME in junior positions (>35%) than senior (<65%) in education, compared to staff recorded as white (>26% junior to <74% senior) in 2020. The growth rate was in the junior levels for staff recorded as BAME (increasing to 13% of all staff in 2020 from 7% in 2015). Senior levels saw far less growth, from <7% in 2015 to only <9% in 2020. For both junior and senior staff, the comparison was similar for the ethnicity of those awarded fixed-term and open-ended contracts, with a slightly higher proportion of staff recorded as BAME on fixed-term contracts (17%) than staff recorded as white (14.5%). The increase in the employment of staff recorded as BAME in fixed-term contracts in education was at an overall growth rate of <17%, half that of the UK

HE sector (>33%). There was a more substantial rate of growth for education staff recorded as BAME on permanent contracts (<45%), than the rate in the UK HE sector (<37%).

The proportion of education staff recorded as BAME who had progressed to professors in 2020 increased to >6% over the period studied. There were no professors in education recorded as Asian/Asian British Bangladeshi; no female professors in education recorded as black/black British African nor other black background; and no male professors recorded as black/black British Caribbean nor other black background.

In terms of the proportions of those in senior management, staff recorded as BAME had lower proportions (>2%) than the proportions observed in those staff recorded as white (<5%).

3.1.4 Disability

Across the UK HE sector in 2020, 93% of staff were recorded as having no known disability, 5% reported a known disability and 2% were recorded as unknown. Similarly, education recorded 93% of staff with no known disability, and a slightly higher reporting of known disability at 6%, with 1% recorded as unknown. Across the study period, both education and the UK HE sector had seen an increase in the reporting of 'known disability'. In education, it was recorded at 6% in 2020, a 23% growth rate compared to the UK HE sector's growth rate of >36%.

In certain age bands, education saw higher proportions of disability reported than the UK HE sector, with a difference ranging from >8% to 2%. While findings are tentative because of inconsistencies across the years, the age bands where reporting was most notable were those 25 years and under, with >14% known disability in 2020.

Of those staff with known disabilities reported, there were similar proportions of female to male staff in education. There was a small difference between the proportions of those recorded as white (>6%) and that of those recorded as BAME (5.5%). However, consistently in the five years studied, education had a higher proportion of those recorded as BAME with known disability (5.5%) than the UK HE sector (<3%).

For the devolved nations, education in England reported consistently higher proportions of known disability – with a range from 15.3% to 5.3% per age band – all at higher proportions than its local HE sector. The two largest age bands for education staff in Northern Ireland each reported high proportions of known disability: for the 51 to 55 age band, >21% reported a known disability; for the 56 to 60 age band, 13.5% reported a known disability.

3.1.5 Religious belief

Across the UK HE sector in 2020, responses to religious belief were 55% information refused; 24% no religion and not available; 15% Christian; 5% Buddhist, Hindu, Jewish, Muslim or Sikh; and 2% ‘spiritual and other’. In education, the responses were 51% information refused; 22% Christian; 21% no religion and not available; 3% ‘spiritual and other’ and 3% Buddhist, Hindu, Jewish, Muslim or Sikh. The higher proportion was in staff recorded as Christian in education than in the UK HE sector (a difference of 7%). In education, there were lower proportions of staff whose religious belief was ‘spiritual and other’, and in the combined group of Buddhist, Hindu, Jewish, Muslim and Sikh. As the numbers were small for analysis, these two groups were combined for analytical purposes. Responses to the category of ‘religious belief’ differed considerably in education

in each of the devolved nations. Findings about education in general are provided first, followed by each category.

In education, after ‘information refused’, the highest recorded response for female staff was Christian (24%). For male staff, the highest recorded response was ‘no religion’ (24%). Both these proportions mirrored the UK HE sector.

When limited to the proportions of those with religious belief, in education those recorded as white had higher proportions recorded as Christian (<83%). This differed to those recorded as BAME of whom a proportion of >56% were recorded as ‘spiritual and other’, Buddhist, Hindu, Jewish, Muslim and Sikh. Although there was more plurality of belief for education staff recorded as BAME, this was a lower proportion than in the UK HE sector (68%). Of those recorded as BAME and Christian (<44% in education), the proportion was >11% higher than the proportion in the UK HE sector. However, this was not consistent across the devolved nations, as noted below.

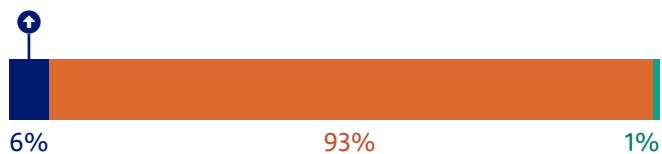
The FTE patterns for those who indicated a religious belief were similar in terms of the proportions of fixed-term to permanent contracts, and junior to senior levels.

Disability of academic staff in education in UK HE (2015-2020)

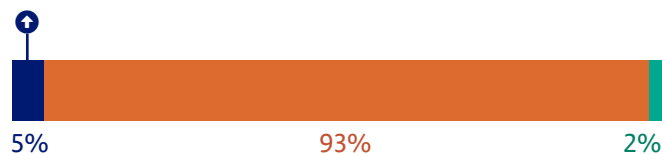
Reported dis/ability in education compared to the UK HE sector (FPE; 2019-20)

● Known disability ● No known disability ● Unknown

Education



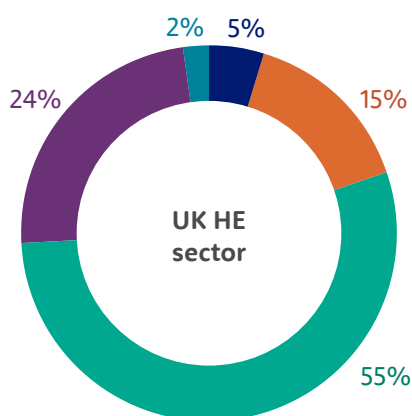
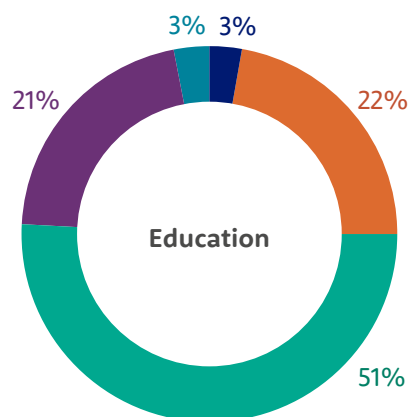
UK HE sector



Religious belief of academic staff in education in UK HE (2015-2020)

Responses to religious belief in education compared to the UK HE sector (FPE; 2019-20)

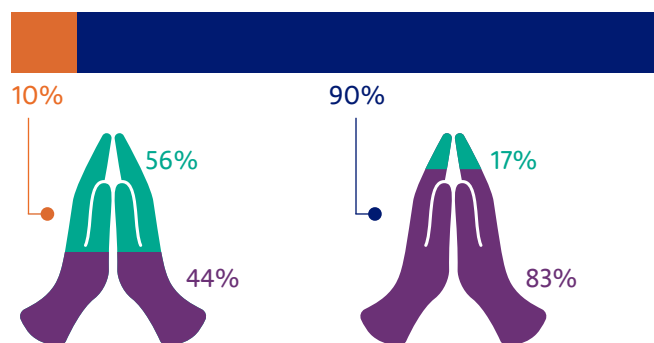
● Buddhist, Hindu, Jewish, Muslim, Sikh
● Christian
● Information refused
● No religion
● Spiritual and other



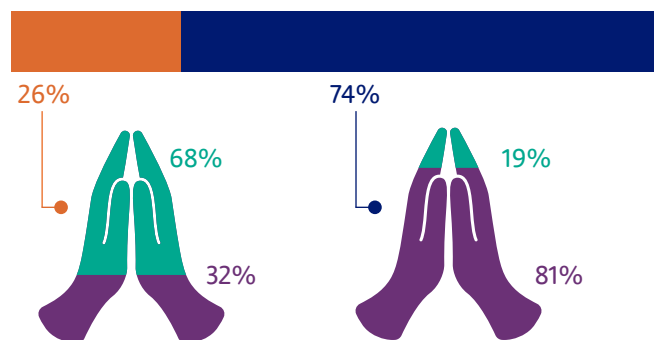
Ethnicity with proportions of religious belief only in education compared to the UK HE sector (FPE; 2019-20)

● BAME ● White

Education



UK HE sector



● Christian
● 'Spiritual and other' and Buddhist, Hindu, Jewish, Muslim, Sikh

Findings of Belluigi, Arday and O'Keeffe (2023) informed by HESA statistical data

Information refused

The largest proportion in education were those who refused to record information about religious belief, on average over half of the proportion across the UK, although this differed considerably in each of the devolved nations. Education recorded 57% in Scotland, 56% in Northern Ireland and 51.5% in England. These were within 5% of the proportions observed in their local HE sector. Proportions in Wales differed. A far lower proportion of staff refused information (30%), at a much lower proportion than that local HE sector (43%).

No religion and not available

The recording of 'no religion' and 'not available' increased in the study period in both education (from 17% to 21%) and the UK HE sector (16.5% to 24%). In 2020, the largest proportion was in Wales (32%), followed by Scotland (22%) and England (21%), with a considerably lower proportion in Northern Ireland (<6%). These were all lower proportions than their local HE sectors, with the exception of education in Wales, which recorded 30% in its local HE sector.

Christian

There was a greater proportion of staff in education recorded as Christian (22%) than in the UK HE sector (<15%). The largest proportion was recorded in Wales (35%), followed by Northern Ireland (30%) and England (22%), with the smallest proportion in Scotland (12%). However, all were higher than in their local HE sectors, at a difference that ranged from 13% in Wales to 5% in Scotland. The proportion of professors recorded as Christian was 4.5% in education, far lower than in the UK HE sector (>8%). Only in England and Wales were senior managers recorded whose religious belief was reported as Christian.

The highest proportion of staff recorded as BAME and Christian was in Wales, at 84% in education compared to >37% in the local HE sector. Of those staff recorded as white, the highest recording of Christians in education across the devolved nations was in Wales (>92%, compared to the local HE sector at >85%).

Buddhist, Hindu, Jewish, Muslim, Sikh, 'spiritual and other'

Scotland reported the largest proportion for education staff recorded as Buddhist, Hindu, Jewish, Muslim, Sikh, 'spiritual and other' (>9%), which increased over the study period consistent with its local HE sector. However, there was a lower proportion of such staff in professor positions (>1%) in education compared to its local HE sector (8.5%), with those in senior management (<3%) from education slightly higher than the proportion of its local HE sector (<2%).

Northern Ireland had seen increases to a proportion of <8% of such education staff in the period studied. None of those who were recorded as Buddhist, Hindu, Jewish, Muslim, Sikh, 'spiritual and other' were professors in education in Northern Ireland, compared to <10% in the local HE sector. However, >9% of such education staff were in senior management in Northern Ireland.

A slight decrease to <6% in this grouping was observed in England over the study period. Wales had the lowest proportion at >3%, with no professors or senior management in education in this grouping, compared to <12% professors and 1.5% senior management in the local HE sector.

3.1.6 Primary nationality

Primary nationality and staff composition

Across the UK HE sector in 2020, the reporting of staff primary nationality was 68% UK, 17% EU and 14% non-UK/EU. In education, the proportion of UK staff was large at 88%, with 7% EU and 5% non-UK/EU.

Thus, education was predominantly composed of staff recorded as holding UK primary nationality. While there had been a decrease in the rate of UK staff employed (-2.2%) in the period studied, that proportion remained significantly higher than in the UK HE sector, at a 20% difference in 2020. The reductions seen across both education and the UK HE sector had filtered into the proportions of staff recorded as holding EU primary nationalities. However, there was significantly less access to education for those recorded as holding EU primary nationalities (10% difference to the sector) and non-EU/UK primary nationalities (>9% difference to the UK HE sector). This was despite the higher rates of growth in the employment of those recorded as EU in education compared to the UK HE sector (15.6% in education to 9.6% in the UK HE sector) and those recorded as non-EU/UK compared to the UK HE sector (>56% in education to >29% in the UK HE sector).

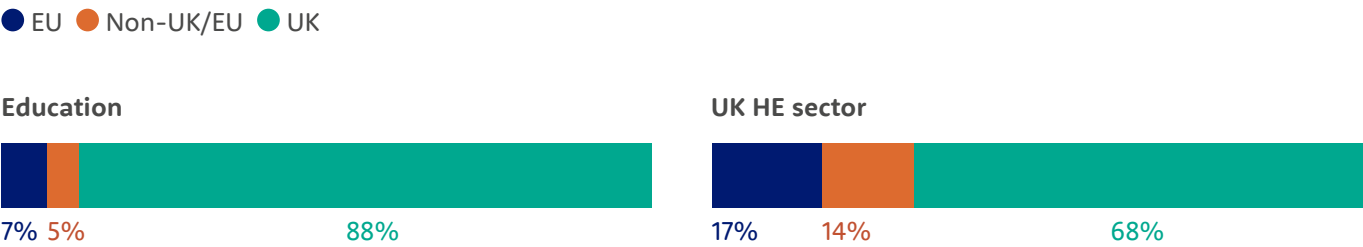
Differences emerged when nationality was considered in relation to ethnicity. Those of UK primary nationality were recorded as 94% white to >6% BAME. Of those with EU primary nationalities, there was a large proportion of those recorded as BAME (6%). However, a higher proportion of those recorded as BAME was observed when analysing the grouping of staff holding non-EU/UK primary nationalities (53%).

When the data were analysed by grouping primary nationality in the categories UK, EU, non-EU/UK, the general pattern of more female to male staff was observed. However, that pattern was different when the data were analysed according to the income status of the country of primary nationality. The lower the economic status of the country of primary nationality, the higher the proportion of male staff to female, as outlined in the section above on sex. The general pattern of more male to female staff was reversed for low- and middle-income countries (LMICs) with smaller proportions of female staff employed in education.

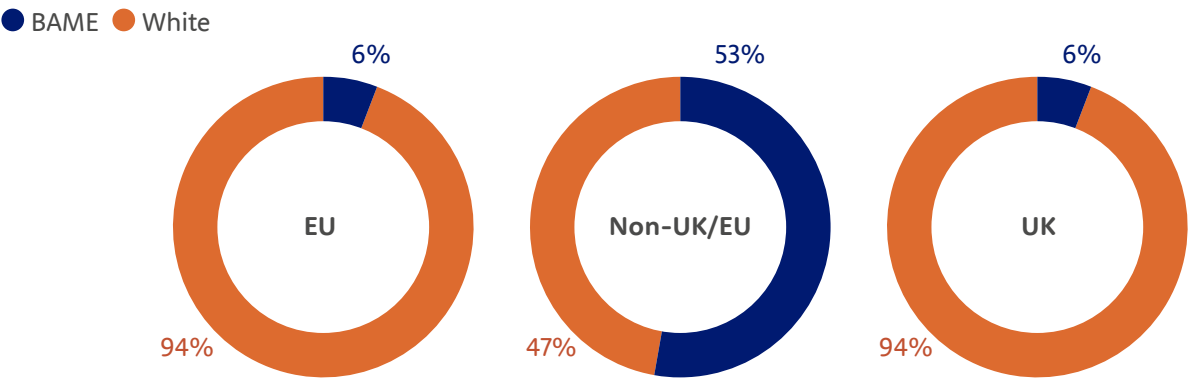
Education staff held primary nationalities from high-, upper-middle-, middle-, or low-income countries. However, the vast majority were from high-income countries (>97% in 2020), at a higher proportion when compared to the UK sector (90%). Most staff from high-income countries in education were from the UK, Ireland, Greece, Germany, Italy, Australia, Canada, the Netherlands and Spain. Less than 2% of education staff held primary nationalities in upper-middle-income countries, less than the proportion in the UK HE sector (6% in 2020). Access for education staff from middle-income countries was even further reduced. During the study period, this increased to only >1% in education in 2020, lower than the under-representation observed in the UK HE sector (>4%). The proportion of staff employed from low-income countries was so low it was rounded to zero in both education and in the UK HE sector as a whole.

Primary nationality of academic staff in education in UK HE (2015-2020)

Grouped primary nationality in education compared to the UK HE sector (FPE; 2019-20)

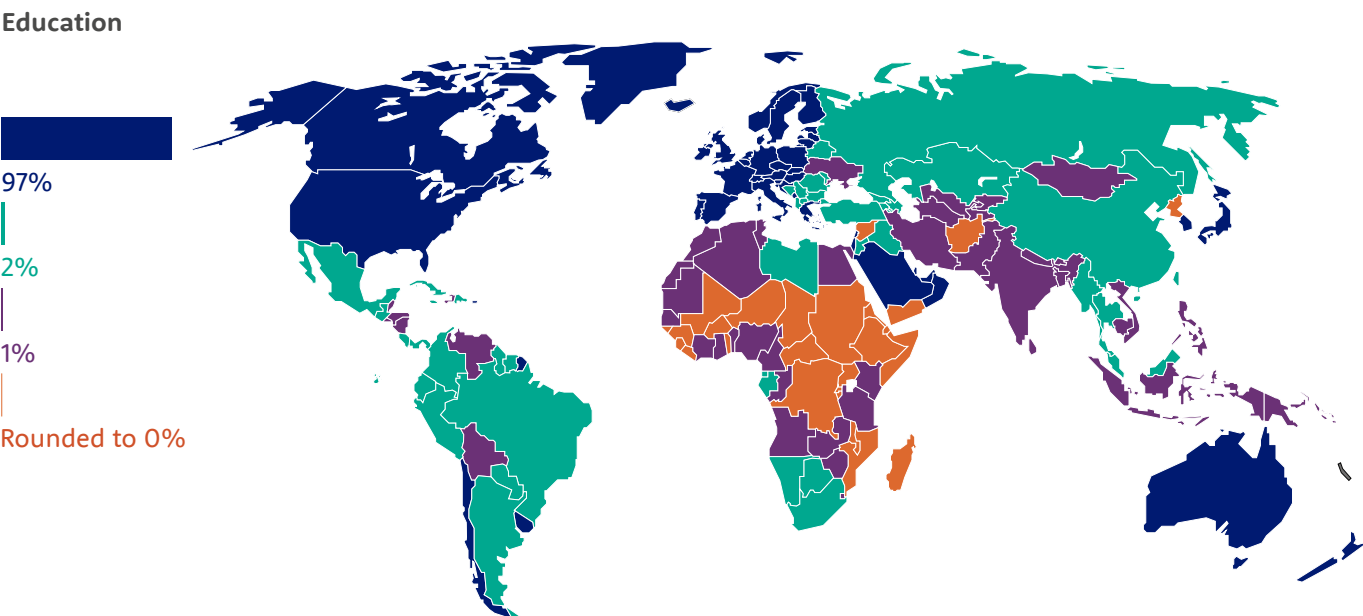


Grouped primary nationality with proportions of ethnicity (FPE; 2019-20)



Country income group (FPE; 2019-20)

● High-Income ● Upper-Middle-Income ● Lower-Middle-Income ● Low-Income

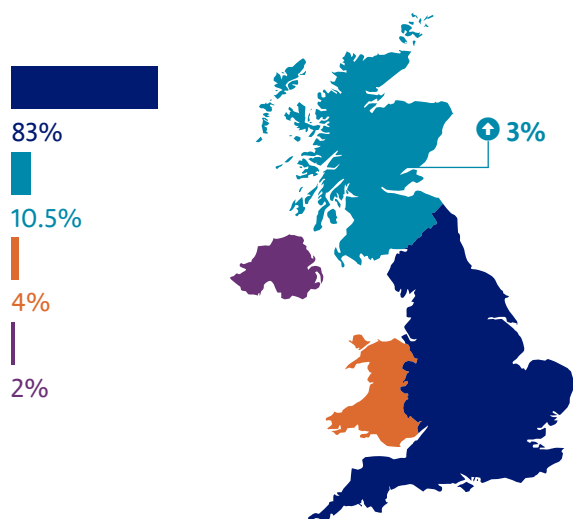


Findings of Belluigi, Arday and O’Keeffe (2023) informed by HESA statistical data

Education in the devolved nations of UK HE

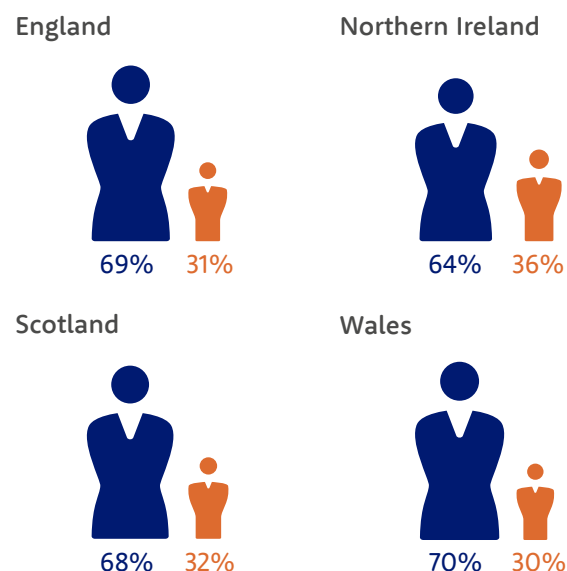
Proportion of staff in education in the four devolved nations (FPE; 2019-20)

● England ● Northern Ireland ● Scotland ● Wales



Sex proportions of staff in education in the four devolved nations (FPE; 2019-20)

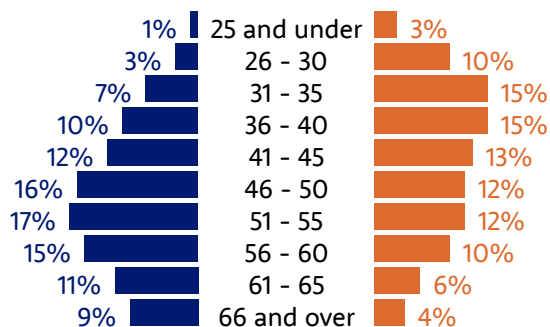
● Female ● Male



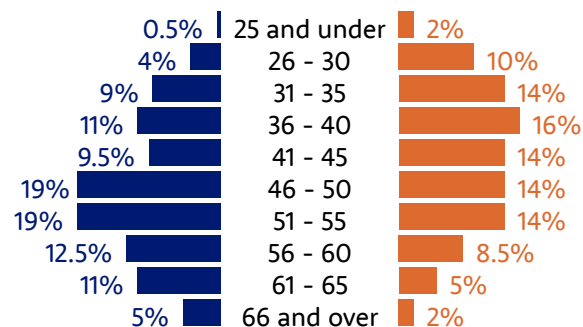
Age bands; education compared to the local HE sector in the four devolved nations (FPE; 2019-20)

● Education ● Local HE sector

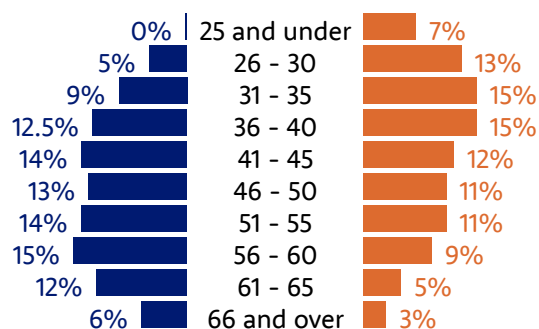
England



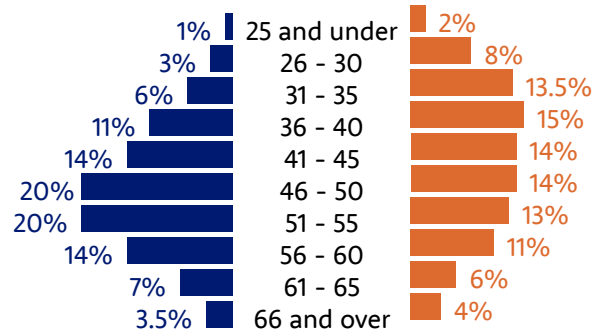
Northern Ireland



Scotland



Wales



Findings of Belluigi, Arday and O'Keeffe (2023) informed by HESA statistical data

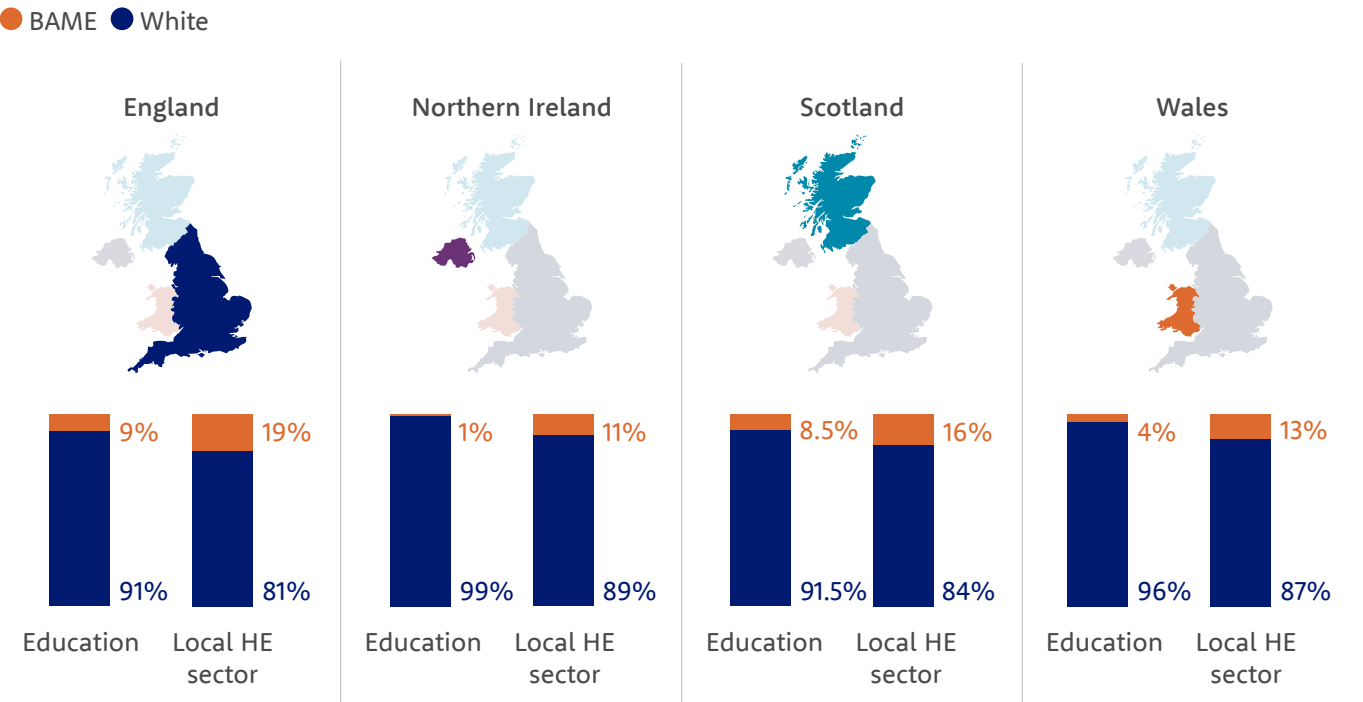
When considering employment conditions, there was a higher proportion of those from upper-middle-income countries (<9%) and middle-income countries (>7%) at junior levels, compared to senior levels. The proportion of education staff at senior levels from upper-middle-income countries was 4% and from middle-income countries was 3%. At the level of professor in education, 97% were recorded as holding primary nationality in high-income countries, <1% upper-middle-income countries and >1% middle-income countries. There were none from low-income countries. For senior management appointments, the proportion of all those from low- and middle-income countries was rounded to zero.

Primary nationality and the devolved nations

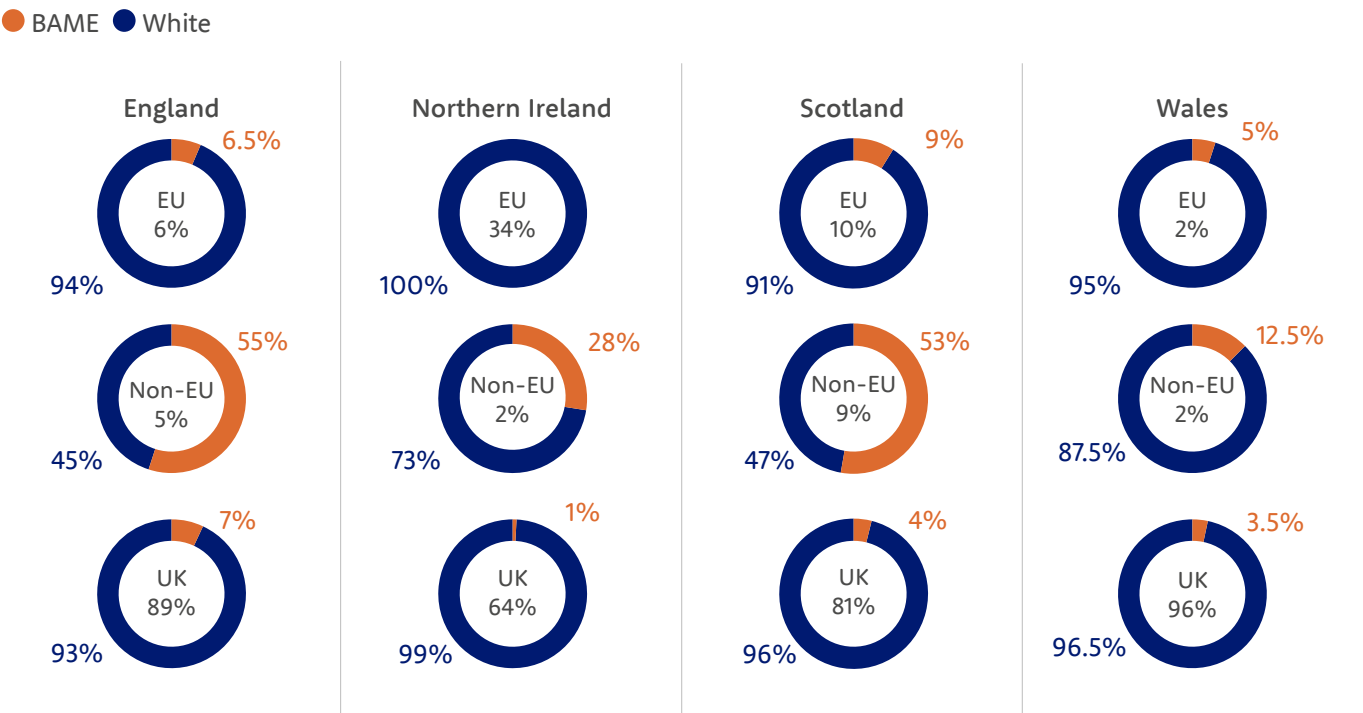
Consistent across the devolved nations were the higher proportions of staff with UK primary nationality employed in education than in the local HE sectors. The largest proportion in education was observed in Wales (>96%), followed by England (>89%), Scotland (80%) and Northern Ireland (64%). Of those holding EU primary nationalities, the largest proportion was in Northern Ireland (34%) of which a sizeable portion held the primary nationality of the Republic of Ireland. Scotland recorded the next largest proportion (>10%), followed by England (6%) and Wales (>2%), each with considerably lower proportions than their local HE sectors. Of those employing staff with non-EU/UK primary nationality, Scotland had the largest proportion at 9%, then England <5%, Northern Ireland 2% and Wales <2%, all significantly lower than their local HE sectors.

Education in the devolved nations of UK HE

Devolved nations by ethnicity in education compared to the local HE sector (FPE; 2019-20)



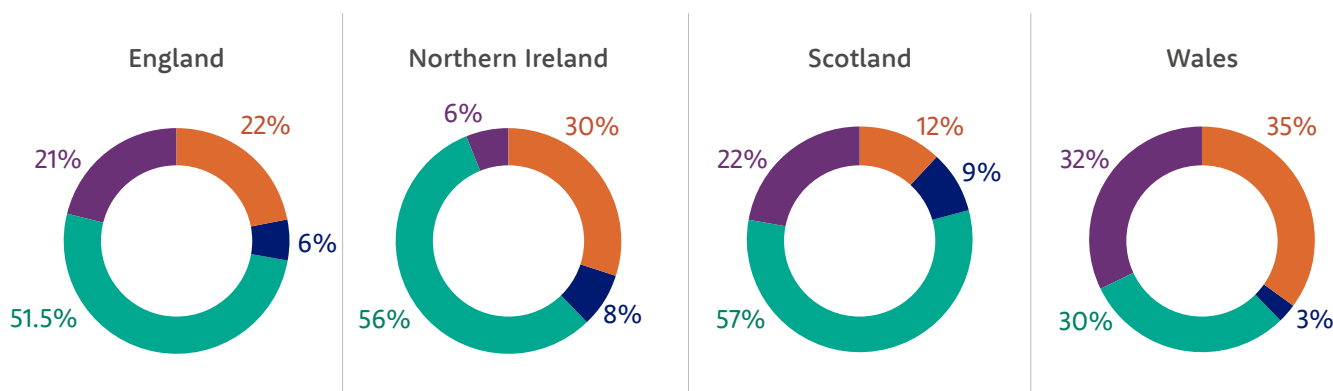
Devolved nations by primary nationality and ethnicity in education (FPE; 2019-20)



Findings of Belluigi, Arday and O’Keeffe (2023) informed by HESA statistical data

Devolved nations, responses to religious belief in education (FPE; 2019-20)

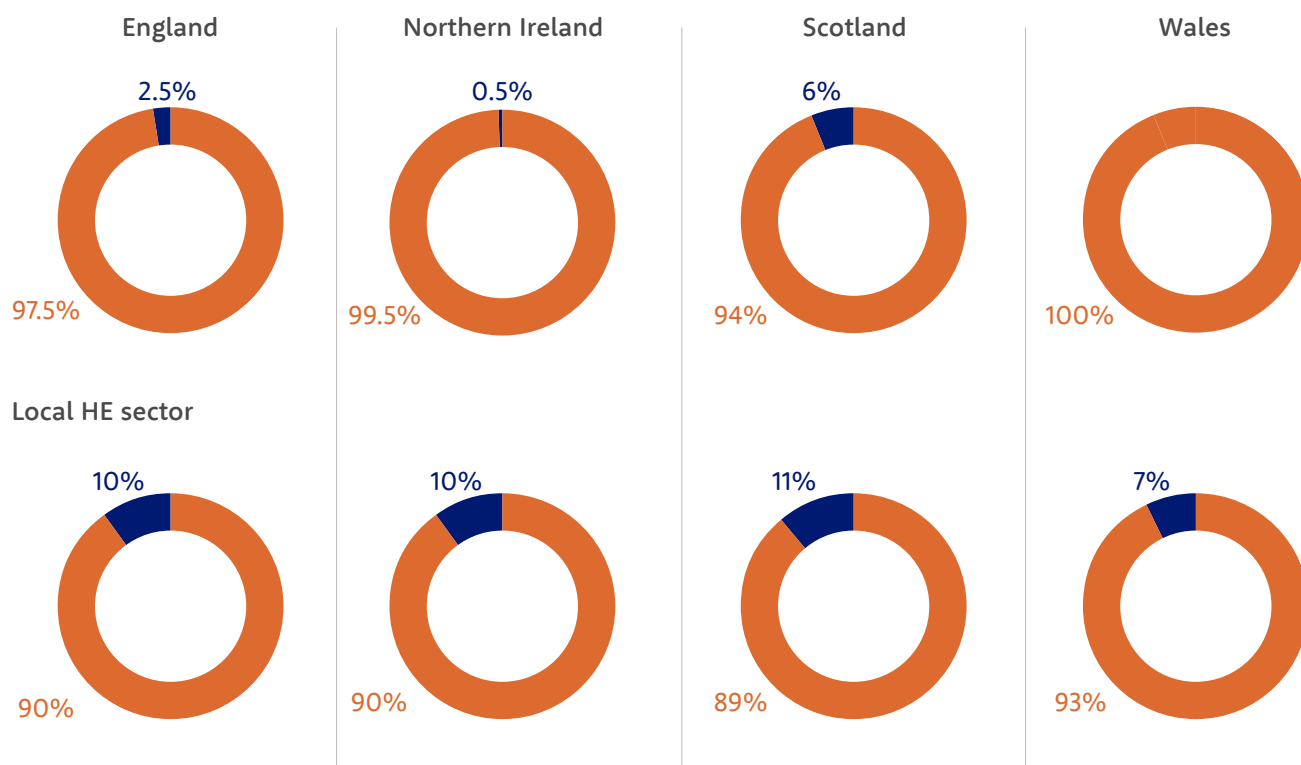
● Christian ● 'Spiritual and other' and Buddhist, Hindu, Jewish, Muslim, Sikh ● Refused ● Unknown or no religion



Devolved nations, income country proportions of education compared to the local HE sector (FPE; 2019-20)

● High-Income Countries ● LMICs

Education



Findings of Belluigi, Arday and O'Keeffe (2023) informed by HESA statistical data

3.2 PART B: EXPLORATION OF 'STARTERS', ATTAINMENT AND PROGRESSION, AND ATTRITION IN EDUCATION

When considering patterns of staff composition and participation in HE, changes over time are helpful for indicating whether conditions have improved, deteriorated or remained the same. Three areas of possible change in education in the period 2015 to 2020 were employment of staff in new contracts ('starters'); staff promotions (including attainment and progression); and attrition of staff ('leavers'). As an analysis of the movement of people, rather than how contracts were filled, FPE statistics have been utilised for the analyses in this part of the report.

While the intention was to identify whether the hiring and promotion of staff indicated that inequalities in employment were being addressed in the discipline, no significant patterns were discernible in the dataset. In addition, the small amounts (particularly for groups in the minority) and the short timescale studied limited the confidence of any such claims. Thus, in this section, notable findings only are presented. Analysis of starters is based on 2016-20 and leavers 2015-19. This means that leavers are based on earlier and potentially lower populations due to increases in staff employment in the later dates.

3.2.1 'Starters' in education

During the study period, the average proportion of 'starters' in the UK HE sector was >9% of all staff. In education, the average was 8%.

In the last year of the dataset (2020), the proportion of staff recorded in education as 'starters' was <8%, which was the same proportion as the UK HE sector, albeit with

different actual numbers. The composition of 'starters' according to sex in that year was predominately female (>69%), of which the highest proportion was in the 36 to 40 age-group (>77%) and the lowest proportion was in the 66+ age-group (>42%), with the inverse for male staff.

Staff starting in education in 2016 were recorded as white (>78%), unknown (25.5%) and BAME (6.5%). The proportion of starters recorded as BAME was higher in 2020 at >11%, of which those recorded as Asian was the largest proportion at >5%, with staff recorded as black at 2.5% and those recorded as mixed at 2%.

The ethnicity of those entering education at professorial level in education was analysed. More of those recorded as white started in the timeframe, from 37.5% in 2016 to 73.5% in 2020. The starters who were recorded as mixed seemed to decrease from 31% in 2016 to 0% in 2020. Similarly, for 'other' BAME staff there was a decrease from >31% in 2016 to >6% in 2020. No staff recorded as Asian or black started as professors during the period studied.

In 2016, the majority of starters in education held UK primary nationality (>79%) and the lowest proportion was reported as non-EU/UK primary nationality (>6%). In 2020, these figures increased to >85% for those with UK primary nationality and to >8% for those recorded with non-EU/UK primary nationality, with lower proportions of starters holding EU primary nationalities.

3.2.2 Exploration of the data on attainment and progression

The proportions of those who were promoted (that is 'attainment') in the whole UK HE sector during the period studied increased from >6% in 2016 to >7% in 2020. In education, the proportion of those promoted increased marginally from below to above 6% (due to the rounding of percentages) in the same period. Across the whole UK HE sector, the proportion of those who progressed to professor positions increased from >9% in 2016 to 11.5% in 2020, compared to an increase from >3% in 2016 to >9% in 2020 in education. The UK HE sector saw progression to senior management decrease from <9% in 2016 to 5.5% in 2020. In education, the decrease in progression from senior management was from 7% in 2016 to >4% in 2020. It was clear from this that promotion and progression in education is at a lower level than in the UK HE sector as a whole.

Of female staff promoted in education in 2020, the highest proportion was in the 51 to 55 age-group (>17%). The largest proportion of male staff promoted in education in 2020 was in the 41 to 45 age-group (>24%).

The proportion of staff in education recorded as BAME who were promoted between 2016 and 2020 increased from >7% to >10%. Of those, the data imply that the lowest proportion was those recorded as black (<2%).

Those promoted in education between 2016 and 2020 were recorded as predominately holding UK primary nationality, with a decrease in that proportion from >86% to >80%. The lowest proportion of those promoted was those holding non-EU/UK primary nationalities, albeit that proportion of promotions had doubled over the period studied from <4% to <9%.

Of those promoted in education in 2020, senior academics were a higher proportion (>73%) than junior academics (21%). When grouped by professor, senior manager and other contract level, the largest proportion of promotions was for 'other contract level', which decreased slightly from 88% to >85%. In 2020, this included those recorded as Asian (<5%), mixed (2%), other (<2%) and black (>1%). There was an increase in the proportion of professors promoted, from >3% in 2016 to >9% in 2020. Of the professors promoted in education, <83% were recorded as white, <8% as Asian, <6% as other, and <2% as mixed. No promotions at professorial level were observed for education staff recorded as black. The proportion of those promoted to senior management decreased from <9% to 5.5%. Of those staff promoted to senior management in 2020 <91% were recorded as white, >6% black and 3.2% as Asian.

3.2.3 Attrition in education

The average for the proportion of attrition in the whole UK HE sector during the period studied was 9%. In education, the average proportion of attrition was 8.5%.

The proportion of attrition by sex in education increased from >66% to >67% for female staff, with the proportion of male staff decreasing slightly from <34% to <33%. Of those female staff leaving education in 2019, the highest proportion was in the 56 to 60 age-group (<18%). The largest proportion of male staff leaving education in 2019 was in the 66+ age-group (<22%).

There was an average of 8% of 'leavers' whose ethnicity was recorded as 'unknown'. Attrition for staff recorded as BAME increased from <5% to 7%. When the known ethnicities of those staff recorded as BAME were explored further, the proportions of attrition from lowest to highest were those recorded as other (<1%), black (<1%), mixed (<2%) and Asian (<4%).

Further exploration of ethnicity and attrition in education was undertaken for the last possible year of the study period (2019). The largest ethnic grouping was those staff recorded as white. Beyond this, <22% attrition was recorded for those with ethnicity 'unknown' leaving an 'other contract'. At junior level, attrition included those recorded as Asian (>4%), mixed (<2%), other (<1%) and black (>1%), with a large percentage for whom ethnicity was unknown (10.5%). At senior level, attrition included those recorded as unknown ethnicity (>4%), Asian (>3%), mixed (<2%) and other (<2%). Attrition in senior management in education included only those recorded as Asian (>3%) and white.

Between 2015 and 2019 there was a decrease in attrition of those holding UK primary nationality in education (from <91% to >87%). Attrition of those holding EU primary nationalities increased slightly from >5% to >6%. Attrition more than doubled for those holding non-EU/UK primary nationalities, from >2% to <5%.

3.2.4 Reasons for leaving

The proportions in this section are averages over the period studied unless otherwise indicated. Reporting is on the reasons for leaving. However, the reasons for leaving were not recorded for a considerable proportion of staff – 21% in the whole UK HE sector and <36% in education. The figures below have not been adjusted.

When considering overall reporting of the reasons for leaving, most of the proportions in education were similar to those within the UK HE sector, except for retirement (<8% in education compared to >3% in the UK HE sector) and voluntary redundancy (<4% in education compared to <3% in the UK HE sector). Dismissal and ill-health accounted for an average of 3.5% in education (similar to the UK HE sector), and 'other redundancy' was an average of 3.4% (lower than the UK HE sector by 1%). Resignation was slightly less than in the UK HE sector at >23% compared to >29%.

For ethnicity, there were some differences in the reasons recorded for leaving HE. Of those recorded as BAME, the largest proportions of reasons for leaving were resignation (<28%), end of fixed-term contract (22%), 'other (including dismissal or ill health)' (>7%), and continued employment in HE (>6%). Retirement (>3%) and voluntary redundancy (<3%) were lower proportions. Of those recorded as white, the largest proportion of reasons for leaving was the end of fixed-term contract (>20%), then resignation (19%), retirement (<8%), continued employment (6.5%), voluntary redundancy (5%), other redundancy (<4%), and 'other (dismissals and ill health)' (3%).

The reason 'continued employment, new HESA contract record generated' highlighted the employment, and possibly re-employment, of older staff in education. High proportions of leavers were recorded from age 56+. Specifically, in education, those who left at age 56 to 60 were >12% of the proportion of leavers; those aged 61 to 65 were 19% of the proportion of leavers; and those aged 66+ were 16% of leavers. When compared to the UK HE sector, staff aged from 56 to 60 were 8% of the proportion of leavers; those aged 61 to 65 were 4.5% of the proportion of leavers; and those aged 66+ were <3% of the proportion of leavers.

Different reasons for attrition were recorded according to sex. Slightly higher proportions of female staff (21%) recorded the reason for leaving as 'end of fixed-term contract', than the proportion of male staff (18%). Slightly more female staff recorded 'resignation' (21%) compared to male staff (18%). A higher proportion of female staff (16%) were recorded as retiring than the proportion of male staff (9%). A higher proportion of attrition in female staff was due to death (7.5%) than in male staff (1.3%). A higher proportion of the male staff recorded 'other (includes dismissal and ill-health)' (<5%) than the proportion recorded for female staff (<3%).

When comparing permanent staff (<36%) and those on fixed-term contracts (<11%) in 2019, resignation was the largest reason recorded for leaving, with both groupings having slightly lower proportions than the UK HE sector. However, there seemed to be an increase in resignations of permanent staff in both education (from <24% in 2016 to 40% in 2019) and in the UK HE sector (from 40% in 2016 to 48% in 2019). There was a large proportion of staff in permanent contracts whose reasons were recorded as dismissal or ill-health (5%), at a higher proportion than that of the UK HE sector (3.5%). Voluntary redundancy (8%) and other redundancy (5.5%) for those in permanent contracts were in lower proportions compared to the UK HE sector.

4. Discussion

The findings above offer snapshots of the state of the composition and employment conditions of education staff as recorded in the HESA data. They indicate the problematically homogenous state of education in the UK. However, the findings do not provide insights as to why this is the case or what can be done about it. There is considerable international scholarship about how academics are perceived and positioned by in-groups and those with assigned power; how that affects the access, positioning, participation and conditions for flourishing of those who are excluded, minoritised and delegitimised; and how the cultures, norms and functions of disciplinary and institutional cultures are enriched, impoverished and transformed by in/equalities. This includes the cultivation of un/democratic practices and academic un/freedoms.

In this section, the researchers briefly highlight and discuss specific findings of this study, and bring them into proximity with selected scholarship on cognate issues that have been reported about UK HE in order to encourage further research and discussion about the state of in/equality in education.

4.1 INSUFFICIENT AND PROBLEMATIC GROWTH IN EDUCATION

Where there is growth in employment, there is arguably more opportunity and scope to address inequalities and under-representation. The inverse may apply too – where there is less growth or more competition, the existing dominant climate may resist the access,

attainment and progression of those perceived as ‘other’, particularly if employment practices are conservative-leaning or risk-averse when it comes to change. Thus, the finding that employment in education had grown only very slightly in the period studied, and at a far lower rate than that of the whole UK HE sector, is of concern. At the same time, there were indications of slight increases in proportions of attrition in education.

Related to this are concerns about growth at leadership level – both in terms of those positioned as leadership academically (professors) and those in assigned managerial roles (senior management). Relative to the UK HE sector as a whole, a lower proportion of education staff was in a professorial role, despite there being more senior staff in education. In addition, the increases in the rate of growth for progression to such a role were lower in education. Of concern was that, despite the inequalities reported herein, there was a considerable increase in professors recorded as white given access as ‘starters’ to education in the UK in the period studied. This was despite the public discourse about the small proportions of BAME professors in the UK HE sector. Scholarship has pointed to systemic problematics with promotion at such levels (Miller, 2016), and how constructions of leadership intersect with those of race/ethnicity and gender (Arday, 2018b; Rollock, 2021; Singh & Kwhali, 2015).

The growth in employment and attainment of those education staff recorded as BAME as a general category was insufficient and problematic. The growth was at too small

a rate to correct the baseline inequalities of the ethnic composition of education staff. Moreover, the way in which such growth was implemented – that is, primarily at junior grades and in ‘teaching only’ contracts – is counterproductive for addressing ethnic inequalities because of the negative impact it would have on the pipeline to senior, professorial and leadership levels.

Another concern is that one of the primary reasons for attrition of those recorded as BAME was resignation. This was a far higher proportion than the same reason when it came to staff recorded as white. In addition, higher proportions of education staff recorded as BAME had ‘other (including dismissal or ill health)’ as a reason for leaving and reported a known disability. Scholarship has pointed to attrition (Bhopal et al., 2015, 2018) and mental ill-health (Arday, 2022) as symptomatic of discriminatory and exclusionary conditions to which minoritised staff are exposed in UK HE.

While beyond the scope of this study, it is important to recognise that the composition of staff is not autonomous of wider changes, and should thus not be viewed in isolation from general and structural inequalities across HE in the UK and internationally. Increasingly precarious employment in UK HE has affected academic practice (Chen et al., 2015) and academic identities (Read & Leathwood, 2020), and limited support for research development and the career development of those precariously employed (Peters & Turner, 2014). The audit culture, institutional competition and stratification (Boliver, 2015) have exacerbated unequal working conditions within institutions. These have been enacted at meso- and macro-levels, such as through institutional performance management, national ‘excellence’ measures such as the

Research Excellence Framework (REF) and the Teaching Excellence Framework (TEF) (Marques & Powell, 2020), and international university rankings. The hostile environment and Brexit have complicated international staff mobility, recruitment and collaboration. In various ways, these have all affected the central functions of research, teaching and community engagement. Symptomatic of the adverse effects of these are staff mental ill-health (Arday, 2022; Morrish & Priaulx, 2020) and staff attrition (Bhopal et al., 2018). While much of this occurs across the HE sector as a whole, particular studies have pointed to the deteriorating conditions for education as a discipline and its research in particular (Lawn & Furlong, 2009; Stentiford et al., 2021).

4.2 THE HOMOGENEOUS STATE OF EDUCATION IN THE UK

This study found that education was much more homogenous compared to the whole UK HE sector. Education employed considerably higher proportions of staff recorded as white than the UK HE sector as a whole. While there were differences between the devolved nations, a higher proportion of staff recorded as white in education was employed in all devolved nations than in their respective local HE sectors. In addition, in education other primary nationalities were considerably less represented than those staff with UK primary nationality. This too was at lower proportions than in the UK HE sector. While the proportions differed between the devolved nations, each had higher proportions of UK primary nationality education staff than in their respective local HE sectors. This proportion was growing in education during the period studied. Similarly, while there were differences, each devolved nation had higher proportions of staff recorded as Christian in education than in their local HE sector.

In a disciplinary context of such social homogeneity, further research is warranted to explore how social determinates affect the academic participation, freedom, flourishing, wellbeing and leadership of those staff outside dominant norms. Attention should also be paid to how such homogeneity relates to the subject(s), methodologies and knowledge(s) researched and taught.

This homogeneity was observed in education generally across the UK. However, there were differences in education in each devolved nation, and in comparison to their local HE sectors. Shattock and Horvath (2020) explored the relationship between devolution and HE, and noted differences. They argue that while devolution has increased the diversity and regional relations of Scottish and Welsh HE, it has not done so in Northern Ireland in part because of local political stalemate. Devolution has been most negative for England, where removing the resistance of the other nations enabled marketisation.

This study confirms the importance of paying attention to geographical contexts and to how they are represented with scholarship. Citation politics may reward academic publications with titles about large or powerful regions (Torres & Alburez-Gutierrez, 2021), such as the ‘United Kingdom’ rather than specific devolved nations. However, while guarding against methodological nationalism (Gilligan, 2022; Wimmer & Schiller, 2003), HE scholars should accurately represent the context(s) studied when reporting on inequality. They should also seek to address the lack of HE research about education in under-studied contexts and regions, as noted in the systemic scoping review of Boyle et al. (2021).

4.3 THE MARGINALISATION AND EXCLUSION OF STAFF RECORDED AS BAME

The proportion of education staff recorded as BAME was less than half that in the UK HE sector. The findings about staff access, attainment and progression indicated that conditions were considerably less favourable to education staff recorded as BAME than those recorded as white. Those recorded as black were particularly under-represented in education. Female staff recorded as black/black British African were barely represented in education generally, and specifically at professor level, where there were none. The rates of growth for black/black British African staff in education over the period studied were far lower than growth rates in the UK HE sector, and were insufficient for addressing inequalities in access. Given the small proportions of those permitted access from low- and middle-income countries, the complete exclusion of low-income countries, and the unequal proportions of male to female staff appointed to education roles from those contexts, there can be no doubt that black females who are Africa-born are excluded from access to, and attainment and progression in, education. Those recorded as Asian/Asian British Bangladeshi experience similar exclusion.

There is much scope for focused research about education, with precedent from HE studies of integration, coping strategies, resilience and so on. For instance, while this report notes that Asian/Asian-Indian academics in education had slightly more representation than other ethnic groups categorised as BAME, previous research questioned whether the productive transfer of capital of many migrant Indian academics

in UK HE may be adversely affected by the changing habitus of UK HE (Fernando & Cohen, 2016). Other studies have explored the acculturation of migrant academics to the UK from China (Hsieh, 2012; Jiang et al., 2010). However, joining the dots between various forms of marginalisation and injustice is important in order to see the cumulative impact on academic freedom and flourishing. Examples of how analysis of other datasets have revealed problematics include the low rates and low amounts of research funding awarded to black primary investigators by UK funders (UKRI, 2021); and ethnic minority pay gaps in Russell Group universities, with the gender pay gap more pronounced for ethnic minority women and for black and Arab academics (Croxford, 2018). Particular attention should be given to the context under study when it comes to investigations of racism and ethnicity. For instance, racism within Northern Ireland is a known concern (Gilligan, 2018, 2019, 2022) which has not been explicitly explored in HE.

Institutional racism and the ‘whiteness’ of UK academia are active areas of scholarship relevant to structural change and justice (Alexander et al., 2015; Arday, 2018a; Arday & Mirza, 2018; Beckles-Raymond, 2020; Mahony & Weiner, 2020; Pilkington, 2013; Tate & Bagguley, 2017; Tate & Page, 2018). Sectoral approaches to addressing racism, through such means as the Race Equality Charter, have also been studied (Bhopal & Pitkin, 2018; Campion & Clark, 2022; Henderson & Bhopal, 2021; Pilkington, 2020). The insights from this research provide useful avenues for discussion about what might be education’s responsiveness to the marginalisation and exclusion of staff evidenced in this study. The intersection of race/ethnicity and gender in UK HE has been studied (Gabriel & Tate, 2017;

Hall et al., 2022; Stockfelt, 2018; Wright et al., 2007), which, along with this study, show that intersecting inequalities continue to influence who is selected for employment in education.

4.4 THE EXCLUSION OF ACADEMICS FROM THE MAJORITY WORLD

The employment of international academic staff has implications for education’s role in sustainable development. This study found that, within education in UK HE, most staff were recorded as holding primary nationalities in high-income countries (or the Global North or minority world). It is possible that some staff were born in the Global South, or the minority world, and had gained access through additional citizenship held in high-income countries. However, the lack of access to employment of those with low- and middle-income primary nationalities raises questions about the mirroring, and in turn reproduction, within UK education of global inequality. In addition, there were gendered inequalities to be observed in the proportion of those employed in education from the majority world. The general pattern of the high-income majority reversed, with lower proportions of female staff employed compared with male staff. The lower contract levels and disproportionate lack of progression for staff from the Global South indicated problematic conditions in UK HE.

While nationality in itself may not be the determining factor in western knowledge hegemony (Krause, 2016), studies have explored the limits to the agency and contributions of migrant academics to teaching within hegemonic UK HE cultures (Minocha et al., 2019; Rao et al., 2019). Specific conditions within UK disciplines have been

found to alter how such migrant academics' agency is enabled, such as a study of foreign-educated legal scholars who were positioned as 'change agents' rather than 'irritants' (Siems, 2021). Socio-linguistic considerations affect migrants operating in the English-dominated UK HE context (Hsieh, 2012; Sliwa et al., 2021). Perhaps the most active area of research into this subject is on the dynamics of the micro-curriculum of teaching and learning, which includes how those not presenting as UK-born and those newly migrant to UK HE are received (Luxon & Peelo, 2009; such as Tebbett et al., 2021). The impact of the legislated limits to UK migration has long featured in the research (see Mavroudi & Warren, 2013 for instance). There has been less study of the autonomy or agency of UK HE institutions to respond to, resist or shape such agendas. More valid data are required about staff nationalities in order to further explore employment patterns and dynamics in education and to address inequalities.

4.5 CONCERNS ABOUT CONTINUED INEQUALITIES FOR THE FLOURISHING OF FEMALE STAFF

Although there were more female than male staff in education, there was not parity in attainment and progression. Indications were that conditions favoured those male staff employed, with longer durations at senior levels to flourish and to progress. When each group's proportions were considered, higher proportions of male staff progressed to professorship and senior management than that observed within the proportions of female staff. Moreover, despite more female staff being in part-time positions, there was proportionately higher representation of male professors employed part-time. As such, the

favourable conditions in education for those choosing or requiring part-time work (such as those with caring responsibilities), which was demonstrated in the large proportions of part-time staff particularly at junior levels, seemed to come at the cost of progression to the top, and for women particularly. Thus the pipelines of part-time staff in education need further investigation (building on work such as that undertaken by Husbands & Davies, 2000).

The question of the access, positioning and flourishing of females has produced considerable scholarship in UK higher education. Westoby et al. (2021) offers a systematic review of the constraints to and enablements for female academics' success in UK HE. The successes of recent UK practice-based initiatives, such as Athena SWAN (Scientific Women's Academic Network), are well documented (Barnard, 2017; Rosser et al., 2019; Tzanakou & Pearce, 2019). However, that particular intervention has not been of equal benefit to black, Asian and minority ethnic women nor white working class women (Bhopal & Henderson, 2021). Further research is needed into the continued patriarchal dynamics in education as a discipline that is majority female, and the intersectional inequalities of sex, with those of ethnicity, religious belief, age, disability and nationality.

4.6 CONCERNS ABOUT CONDITIONS FOR YOUNGER STAFF

A higher proportion of younger staff in education reported disability than other age groups. There are concerns about rising levels of mental ill-health in early career staff (Morrish & Priaulx, 2020) and within UK HE in general (Wray & Kinman, 2022), and about the need for more situated research into

academics' coping strategies (Urbina-Garcia, 2020). Although conditions in education during the period studied were generally less precarious than in the UK HE sector, younger staff entering education would be experiencing less secure conditions than those who had been employed for longer. With most staff at senior levels and on average considerably older, and with less promotion at junior levels, younger people were in the minority in education. However, without complete quality data, inferences cannot be conclusively made. It is possible that the higher proportion reported in younger staff may have been indicative of more inclusion of those variously abled within education in the period studied, or perhaps the more proactive practices of disclosure or activism within people of younger age groups.

4.7 GAPS IN REPORTING

Large gaps were observed in the data which, in many cases, were significantly higher in proportion in education than that observed in the UK HE sector. These were from the recording of 'unknown' and 'information refused' in the data reported by institutions to HESA. These gaps affected the completeness of the dataset and, in turn, the assuredness of the findings. In some cases, the gaps were in similar or higher proportions to the characteristic under study, particularly for minoritised ethnicities and religious beliefs, known disability and 'leavers'.

There is little from the data that enables inferences of why this is so. Scholars have argued that choices about reporting and disclosure, at the individual level, seem to be affected by the institutional context and by how identities are received (Fox & Gasper, 2020). The lack of disclosure may be

symptomatic of distrust about the handling of such disclosure (Blockmans, 2015), disregard for equality reporting, or eroded belief in the efficacy of such data collection and/or its analysis to inform proactive steps towards change (Read et al., 2020). In HE in the UK, there have long been discourses that reflect deflated and frustrated responses to the dominant 'equality, diversity and inclusion' (EDI) approaches and discourses prevalent across the UK HE sector (Ahmed, 2007; Archer, 2007; Bhopal & Pitkin, 2020; Deem & Morley, 2006; Henderson & Bhopal, 2021; Rollock, 2018). Such responses are warranted in the face of policy-implementation gaps and misalignment. For instance, despite HE institutions increasingly making declarative commitments to address inequalities, there is a lack of structural change demonstrated (Baltaru, 2019). Misalignment occurs when equality and justice become obfuscated by more salient and marketable discourses (Pilkington, 2018), such as diversity (Bowl, 2018) and internationalisation. However, nondisclosure adversely affects studies such as this one. A recent study of academics found that nondisclosure also affected the productivity of those minoritised because of their sexual orientation and gender identity in HE (Nelson et al., 2022).

At the institutional and national levels, gaps in reporting may be the result of a lack of investment in resources, capacity and advocacy for collecting and updating staff data. Acknowledging that implementing compliance measures in HE can be a quagmire and rarely delivers equality of outcome, Scott (2020) posits that institutions should be given some ownership of managing EDI to shift towards reflexive learning. However, unknowns such as those observed in this study may enable the avoidance of

accountability and, in turn, inhibit change. The HESA datasets illustrate the direct relationship between mandatory legislation and the completeness of reporting. For example, the completeness of data reported about male and female staff for ‘sex’.

More clarity and better access to quality, granulated data would improve interpretation. In general, where there is more reporting, this may be a positive sign of cultures being more tolerant of difference within institutional or disciplinary settings, and receptive to disclosure. In such cases, data collection may in turn inform the better provision of services and awareness for inclusion. However, without exploring types of ‘disability’, it was not possible to know whether the increased responses observed in this study related to increased tolerance of various abilities; improved access of education staff with disabilities; or an increase in ill-health. The last is particularly of concern because scholars have noted a rise in mental ill-health in the HE sector generally, as well as in those experiencing inequality and exclusion. Similarly, better categorising and reporting what is currently relegated to ‘other’ under ‘sex’ requires urgent attention if it is to be fit-for-purpose for analysing gendered inequalities.

The restriction to reporting at the institutional level was particularly problematic for analysing global in/equality in education staffing. The history of the UK, and its continued international relations, render the current approach to reporting nationality within HE nonsensical. Both within and beyond the UK, it is possible to hold more than one

nationality. For example, individuals may have more than one nationality because of marriage or civil union; inherited nationality from parents or the relation of the country of birth to another country, including prior colonies or current occupied territories and contexts with special status; and from migration. Over the study period, British naturalisation applications by EU citizens had increased after the 2016 EU referendum for reasons such as perceived loss of status and threat from Brexit (Godin & Sigona, 2022). However, applications for UK naturalisation from those with non-EU/UK nationalities were higher in that period.¹⁰ Similarly, staff may hold more than one nationality and be recorded as ‘EU’ in HESA data.

The ‘primary nationality’ recorded may not accord with staff members’ place of birth or upbringing, the contexts with which they most identify, nor the nationality with which they are associated by their colleagues or selection committees. And although individuals’ nationalities may change, what is not captured are the ‘hidden’ dimensions of national background, making ‘migrant = foreign-born’ a more suitable definition for the studies of migrant academics (Pustelnikovaite & Chillas, 2022). HESA omits other relevant indicators such as academic nationality (Rostan & Höhle, 2014), that is, the country in which the staff member’s last qualification was awarded. It is argued that migrant academics’ inclusion in the UK academic labour market is affected by epistemic in/exclusion based on the country where a PhD was awarded (Pustelnikovaite & Chillas, 2022).

10 Source: https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/government/uploads/system/uploads/attachment_data/file/1076311/citizenship-datasets-mar-2022.xlsx

5. Considerations for future research

This report has explored existing statistical data to identify trends and areas for further research. The datasets warrant further statistical analysis. Indeed, the subject requires further data generation and triangulation from additional sources and methods to construct a more robust picture of the state of education. The fitness of HESA reporting is questionable for analysing employment inequalities, including access to such datasets for research purposes. The significant gaps in reporting should be further explored to understand why they exist and what they indicate.

This report describes the intersectional inequalities found. Robust analysis of the intersections of identity, difference and systems of in/equality and dis/advantage in education are required. A recent systematic review indicated that gender continues to be a central consideration (Nichols & Stahl, 2019). However, this study's findings about education in the UK indicate that more centring of ethnicity/race and the majority world is required.

HESA reporting of sex as 'other' than female or male began in 2017. Very small numbers were reported in education in England in the period studied. Other disciplines recorded amounts in England, Scotland and Wales. There was no recording of 'other' observed in Northern Ireland's local HE sector. Disclosure, reporting and minority/majority inequalities according to gender identity and sexual orientation of staff within education requires further exploration.

Research into the various abilities of education staff is required. Better data would allow for more accurate probing of conditions for those with various abilities and disabilities who have access to employment (Brown & Leigh, 2018; Merchant et al., 2020). There are concerns about conditions for variously abled researchers (Burke & Byrne, 2021), and deaf academics (O'Brien, 2020), and for career progression in predominantly ableist cultures (Brewster et al., 2017; Williams & Mavin, 2015). In light of the tentative findings of this study, there should be more study of chronic ill-health and mental ill-health in education. This is especially pertinent given research into the reception of mental ill-health (Fox & Gasper, 2020), and the experiences of staff at junior grades and those racialised as black (Arday, 2022). Other studies have raised concerns about sickness absenteeism in UK HE (Kinman & Wray, 2021).

Research into age, ageing, the academic life-course and the intersections of gender, race, class and various abilities would be of value for considering staffing issues in education, because of its older population and the dynamics of ageing in relation to sex noted in this study. Social gerontology offers fertile intellectual ground for questions about education in UK HE. See, for instance, Carney's (2018) argument that the intersection of politics and gender is appropriate for the study of ageing societies; the survey of studies on old men's masculinities by Thompson (2019); studies which consider the employment of older women (Meliou & Mallett, 2022); and

the questions to guide researchers posed by Carney and Nash (2020). While many education researchers tend to look towards children and youth studies for research questions, the HE sector is not immune to general demographic trends. Of particular interest is the issue of precarity and ageing, where future generations of educators may not enjoy the relatively comfortable public sector or occupational pensions of the past (Grenier et al., 2020). This should be set against the general retraction of the state as a provider of public services (Lobao et al., 2018) and of the pension shrinkage of the UK HE sector.

The statistical data did not explicitly reveal the impact of socio-economic upbringing and positioning of staff in education. There are studies which have explored various aspects of this, from the costs of success for working class women in UK HE (Hoskins, 2010) through to various everyday signs of social class, such as accents in HE and in teaching more generally (Donnelly et al., 2019, 2022). Some have looked at the intersections of race and class (Reay, 2018). Another important consideration is how the stratification of the educational institutions at which staff study (Boliver, 2013) may impact on access, attainment and progression in the discipline of education. More in-depth research of those in assigned leadership positions in education from social groups who have experienced inequality in the UK would add to existing scholarship (Macfarlane & Burg, 2019; Rollock, 2021; Sang et al., 2013).

Specific research about the barriers to access for groups most excluded and marginalised is required. This study found that this includes staff recorded as Asian/Asian British Bangladeshi (with precedent in research undertaken with students, such as by Anand

& Redclift, 2022; Takhar, 2016) and black/black British African. In addition, research into the intersectional impact from markers of difference such as religious belief (Ramadan, 2017) and gender is warranted. While there have been studies about black staff in UK academia (albeit none in education as a discipline), conditions in the devolved nations may differ, particularly for those who are migrant academics from low- and middle-income countries. The dearth of UK research about those recorded as 'mixed' has been noted (Njaka, 2022).

The findings suggest a dominance of staff from high-income countries. However, the limitations of the HESA reporting of primary nationality disable analysis of the interplay between identities, nationalities and countries. This frustrates those studying internationalisation and its relation to employment and academic participation. Valid data should be generated about education staff nationalities, their qualifications and how these may affect the reception and positioning of staff. Particularly in relation to post-colonial, commonwealth and international relations of Britain globally, study of academic exchange and the appointment of academics within education is warranted, including the categories of 'atypical staff', visiting scholars and so on. This could include the nationality of descent of staff (such as 'African descent'), how they identify, their academic nationality (that is, country of last awarded academic qualification), their positioning within HE institutions prior to access to UK HE, and those born or based within the non-EU/UK context. Of value would be setting such findings against research funding awards, and research subject interests and projects, to see the relationship between those 'studying' such contexts and those authoring the production

of such knowledge. In light of the exclusions found in this study, questions should be raised about claims of ‘mutual’ benefit in academic mobility, collaboration and exchange between education in the Global North-South; of UK education’s relation to sustainable development; and of its decolonisation and internationalisation. Such questions have been raised in scholarship about aspects of global HE (Connell et al., 2018; Grieve & Mitchell, 2020) although not education in UK HE specifically. The dynamics of state regulations, such as equality legislation, the hostile environment and recent visa schemes (Langa et al., 2019), on departmental autonomy when it comes to academic selection and collaboration should be considered.

This study’s findings point to less favourable employment conditions for undertaking research in the discipline of education compared to conditions in the whole UK HE sector. Analysis of the research dynamics in education would be of value, as would considering how these affect the demographics of those appointed to ‘research only’ and ‘research and teaching’ positions; full- and part-time positions; at various grades and so on. Funding bodies, such as UKRI (2020, 2021), and scholars have analysed the research award gaps and funding discrimination according to sex (Bedi et al., 2012; Boyle et al., 2015), and ethnicity and nationality (Belluigi & Joseph, 2021). The award gaps of those in education are important considerations in a discipline dominated by those recorded as white and those with UK primary nationality, and more favourable to male and older staff. Considerations include the pipeline for staff recorded as BAME in ‘research only’ posts in education; ‘international’ staff being employed as replacement labour in elite research-intensive

institutions (Khattab & Fenton, 2016); and the dynamics of ‘passport privilege’ and unbelonging experienced by researchers on fixed-term contracts during the transition imposed by Brexit (Courtois & Sautier, 2022).

This study found more growth in employment of academic staff in the UK HE sector than in education between 2015 and 2020. Further research is required to explore why this is so and the implications of this for addressing or exacerbating inequalities; pipelines and routes into employment in education; and the graduate and postgraduate contexts. There is precedent for this within the UK (Ahmet, 2020; Olenina et al., 2022; Williams et al., 2019). The economic impact of Covid-19, increased neoliberal policies in employment, Brexit, the hostile environment and cuts to staff pensions will continue to affect equality in the discipline of education in UK HE. This needs ongoing attention and further study.

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Appendix:

Description and replication checklist

1. Name	Analysis of equality and diversity data within staffing in UK higher education: Raising questions about the state of the discipline of education
Details	Analysis of statistical data about academic staff composition and employment conditions in the discipline of education in UK higher education
	In a five-year period (2015-2020), within England, Northern Ireland, Scotland, Wales
2. Why	Quantitative measures of academic staff composition provide indications of the in/equalities of the conditions for access, participation, power and flourishing in higher education
Details	The research design was informed by the scoping review of research activity (Boyle et al., 2021), the BERA tender, and the expertise of the research team
3. Materials	Tailored statistical datasets from the Higher Education Statistics Agency (HESA)
Details	HESA dataset purchased via application to Jisc Services Limited. Website address: www.jisc.ac.uk
	Data requested included FPE as one set (headcount) and FTE as another set (employment structuring)
	Terminology for report from UK HE contexts from: HESA: https://www.hesa.ac.uk/definitions/glossary ; https://www.hesa.ac.uk/support/definitions/staff Office of the Students: https://www.officeforstudents.org.uk/publications/office-for-students-notifications/glossary-of-key-words-and-phrases/
	World Bank classifications were used to organise primary nationality data: https://datahelpdesk.worldbank.org/knowledgebase/articles/378834-how-does-the-world-bank-classify-countries
	List of countries per classification: https://datahelpdesk.worldbank.org/knowledgebase/articles/906519-world-bank-country-and-lending-groups
4. Procedures	Excel sheet table reference: https://view.officeapps.live.com/op/view.aspx?src=https:%2F%2Fatabank.worldbank.org%2Fdata%2Fdownload%2Fsite-content%2FCLASS.xlsx&wdOrigin=BROWSELINK
	Permissions, purchases, approach and so on
	Team collaboration and working via shared online platform and email
	Weekly team meetings
	Collated academic references from literature review to group online management reference software: https://www.zotero.org/groups/4566021/edi_in_uk_he
Details	Ethical approval (at HE institution)

	Contracts signed and GDPR confirmation	
	20 days approximately for HESA to supply the data, once quotation has been accepted and contract has been signed by both parties	
	Using the data transformation tool Alteryx, the relevant datasets from 2015-2020 were synthesised into a single set on Excel, with data harmonised against the categories	
	Dataset verified for quality and validity against HESA publicly available datasets	
	Data about education in universities across all UK jurisdictions cleaned and synthesised	
	Table of variables to explore was compiled to guide the study, see Figure 1	
	Mapping conducted to explore any changing demographics of the composition of academic staff and rates of growth over five years through descriptive analysis of differentiated data	
	Identification of where the categorisation of staff, in terms of the protected characteristics of age, sex, race/ethnicity, religious belief, disability and nationality (and the intersections between them), impacted on their access, positioning and attainment within education in the UK	
	Micro-level differentiations were explored (in keeping with the ‘award gap’ reporting of UKRI, 2020), in addition to intersectional analysis against other protected characteristics, employment factors and region to consider the nature of discrimination and the persistence, deterioration or changes to inequalities over time	
	Identification of indicators of social dis/advantage for academics’ careers in education, specifically in terms of access, contract type, progression, assigned leadership and attrition	
5. Who	Research team	
Details	Dina Zoe Belluigi*	Senior lecturer in higher education studies, School of Social Sciences, Education and Social Work, Queen’s University Belfast (Northern Ireland, UK)
	Jason Arday*	Professor of education, University of Glasgow (Scotland, UK)
	Joanne O’Keeffe*	Research associate, School of Social Sciences, Education and Social Work, Queen’s University Belfast (Northern Ireland, UK)
	Colin O’Prey	Information analyst, Queen’s University Belfast (Northern Ireland, UK)
	* Primary employment position at time of writing. For more see author biographies within report.	
6. How	Process of data exploration and analysis	
	Exploratory data analysis using MS Excel, pivot tables, tables and visualisations	
	In the last year of the dataset, and then across five years	
	NOTE: While not without limitations, FPE statistics inform the findings of the staff composition, as a picture of who has been given access to employment in education, while FTE statistics inform the findings on employment conditions, as a picture of how they were employed	
	A logical research work plan was devised to address the research questions as fully as possible:	
	1. What is the staff composition in education across the UK per primary demographic characteristic (for example sex) compared to all UK HE sector per same variable?	

	Breakdown of composition in education staff overall compared to breakdown per composition of all UK staff overall per variable
	Undertaken for each of the groupings of sex, ethnicity, religious belief, age, disability, primary nationality
	2. What is the staff composition in education in each devolved nation per primary demographic characteristic (for example sex) compared to the local HE sector per same variable and the other devolved nations in education?
	Break down each of the staff composition for education in each devolved region compared to their local HE sector, and for education across UK
	Undertaken for each of the groupings of sex, ethnicity, religious belief, age, disability, primary nationality
	3. Which proportions of the above characteristics, and intersections with other characteristics, reveal problematics when compared and/or gaps in the composition?
	Exploration of the intersections in the categories of characteristics of education staff overall compared to breakdown per composition of all UK staff overall per variable
	Staff composition per intersecting variables in education per devolved region, compared to the staff composition per intersecting variables of devolved region staff in general
	4. What does the data reveal about access to education?
	Exploration of the employment conditions for all staff in education compared to UK sector included:
	Exploration of mode of employment in relation to staff composition: full time and part time
	Exploration of term of employment in relation to staff composition: open-ended/permanent and fixed-term
	Exploration of contract grouping in relation to staff composition: senior management, professor, other academic contracts; junior and senior contracts
	Exploration of academic employment function in relation to staff composition: research only, teaching only, research and teaching, and neither teaching nor research
	5. What does the data reveal about the position and contract at entry?
	'Starters' were grouped in education and compared to UK sector.
	Note: Within the five years of data, only those new within education in the second to fifth year of data can be identified.
	Exploration of mode of employment in relation to staff composition: full-time and part-time
	Exploration of term of employment in relation to staff composition: open-ended/permanent and fixed-term
	Exploration of contract grouping in relation to staff composition: senior management, professor, other academic contracts; junior and senior contracts
	Exploration of academic employment function in relation to staff composition: research only, teaching only, research and teaching, and neither teaching nor research
	6. What does the data reveal about attrition in education?
	'Leavers' were grouped in education and compared to the UK sector. Note: can be identified in a given year where no subsequent instance of that member of staff exists in the span of the data. Thus, no leavers could be identified in the last year provided in the dataset.
	Exploration of mode of employment in relation to staff composition: full-time and part-time

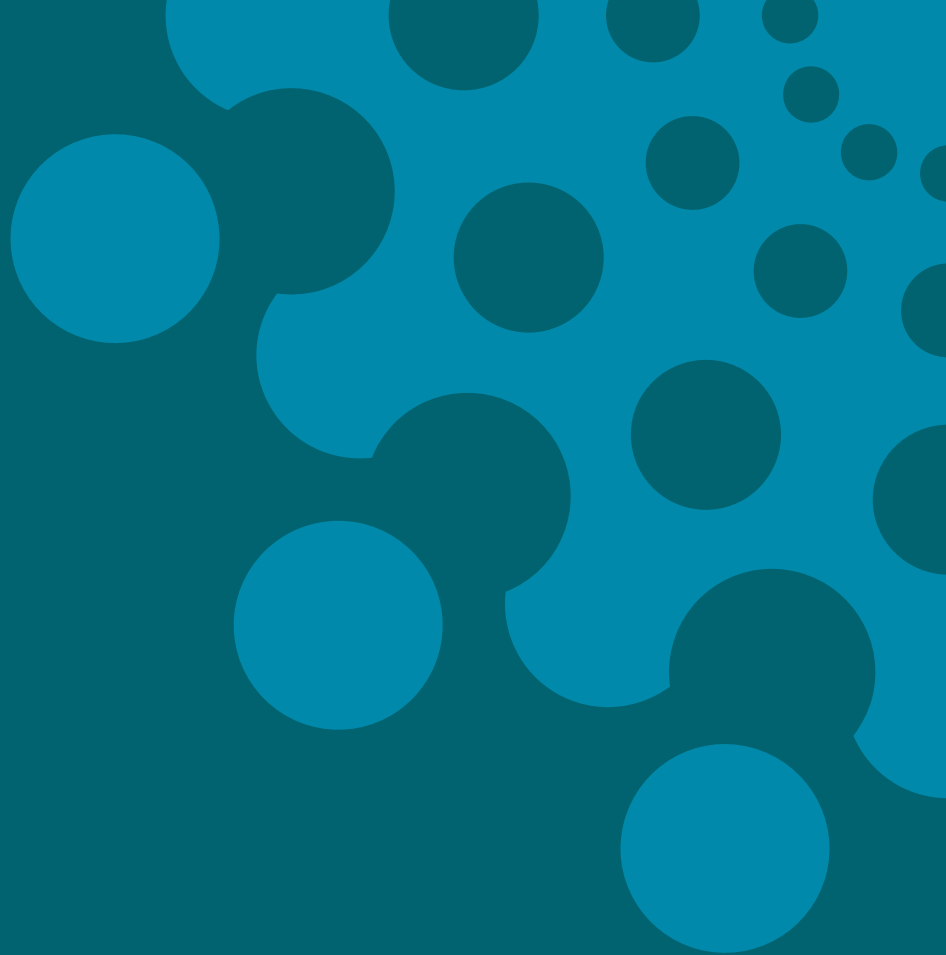
	Exploration of term of employment in relation to staff composition: open-ended/permanent and fixed-term
	Exploration of contract grouping in relation to staff composition: senior management, professor, other academic contracts; junior and senior contracts
	Exploration of academic employment function in relation to staff composition: research only, teaching only, research and teaching, and neither teaching nor research
	Exploration of mode of employment in relation to staff composition: full-time and part-time
	Exploration of reasons for leaving in relation to staff composition
	7. What does the data reveal about attainment?
	Those promoted were grouped in education and compared to the UK sector. Note: Within the five years of data, only those promoted within education in the second and fifth year of data can be identified
	Exploration of mode of employment in relation to staff composition: full-time and part-time
	Exploration of term of employment in relation to staff composition: open-ended/permanent and fixed-term
	Exploration of contract grouping in relation to staff composition: senior management, professor, other academic contracts; junior and senior contracts
	Exploration of academic employment function in relation to staff composition: research only, teaching only, research and teaching, and neither teaching nor research
	8. What does the data reveal about progression?
	The patterns of those staff employed at a highest level, that is professors and assigned senior leadership positions, in relation to staff composition
	Exploration of mode of employment in relation to staff composition: full-time and part-time
	Describe the type(s) of location(s) where the research project and study occurred, including any necessary infrastructure or relevant features
	Exploration of rates of change of education compared to the UK sector
	Duration
	Eight weeks' data analysis
	Four weeks' report collation and Excel spreadsheet of tables for data visualisations
	Three weeks' peer review
	Study modification during the course of the study
	Dataset limitations prevented complete exploration of religious belief, various abilities and disability, full nationalities, and point of entry of migrant academics to access UK higher education
	Dataset limitations prevented tracking across careers of staff
	Two tailored datasets were purchased. This was due to limitations with the first set which was FTE only; without unique identifiers; without data about religious belief; without differentiated ethnicity data; without data about the devolved nations. Second set addressed this and included FPE

About the authors

Dina Zoe Belluigi researches and teaches critical higher education studies. A primary interest in her work is the conditions for the development of critical consciousness in those who represent and commemorate knowledge and knowing, particularly academics and artists, in contemporary ‘post’-colonial times. Racialised as a ‘white’ South African during apartheid, her learning from the possibilities and problematics of academic development, higher education studies and contemporary art practice ‘post’-conflict, has informed her commitment to transformation in higher education and to counter-narratives of author-ity. She has been fortunate to collaborate on and supervise both academic practice and scholarship in contexts across the Majority World; and to act in advisory, review and editorial roles for journals, book publishers, networks, funders, civil society organisations and policymakers. Within the UK, she has most recently served as a member of the external advisory group for EDI for UK Research and Innovation; a board member for the Centre for Global Education; and a council member of the Migrant and Minority Ethnic Think Tank of Northern Ireland. Dina is based at the School of Social Science, Education and Social Work (SSESW) at Queen’s University Belfast, and is affiliated to the chair for the Critical Study of Higher Education Transformation (CriSHET) at Nelson Mandela University in South Africa.

Jason Arday’s work has been informed by an anti-racist approach which builds on policy and community interventions. His work has been hugely impactful in informing policymakers, university senior leaders and stakeholders within the education sector in Britain, having been commissioned by the UK and Welsh Governments to undertake work to develop anti-racist education curricula. Jason is a professor of sociology of education at the University of Glasgow, School of Education, College of Social Sciences. Previously, he was associate professor in the department of sociology and the deputy executive dean for people and culture in the faculty of social science and health at Durham University. Jason is a fellow of the Royal Society of Arts (RSA). He is a visiting research fellow at Ohio State University (USA) in the office of diversity and inclusion and a visiting professor within academic disciplines at Durham University (England), Coventry University (England), London Metropolitan University (England) and Nelson Mandela University (South Africa). He is a trustee of the Runnymede Trust, the UK’s leading race equality thinktank, and a trustee of the British Sociological Association (BSA). Jason sits on the Centre for Labour and Social Studies (CLASS) national advisory panel and the NHS race and health observatory academic reference group.

Joanne O’Keeffe is a researcher in the School of Social Sciences Education and Social Work at Queen’s University Belfast. Joanne’s work is driven by her interest in addressing discrepancies and gaps in education in relation to academic attainment and take-up of higher education opportunities: specifically, students from disadvantaged backgrounds, lower income households and other under-represented groups who may face barriers in education. She is interested in the research and evaluation of widening participation activities in Northern Ireland and currently supports Queen’s University Belfast, widening participation unit (WPU) on suitable evaluation strategies of outreach delivery and creating and evidence-based practice within the unit. Joanne is a member of the future focus steering committee, which is aimed at aligning widening participation activities to the widening participation strategic outcomes of both the institutional and government policies on widening participation. She is a member of the school of social sciences, education and social work ethics committee. Internationally, she sits as the program chair for the American Education and Research Association cooperative learning special interest group and is an editorial board member for the *International Journal of Educational Research*. Joanne is an accredited Office for National Statistics safe researcher.



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